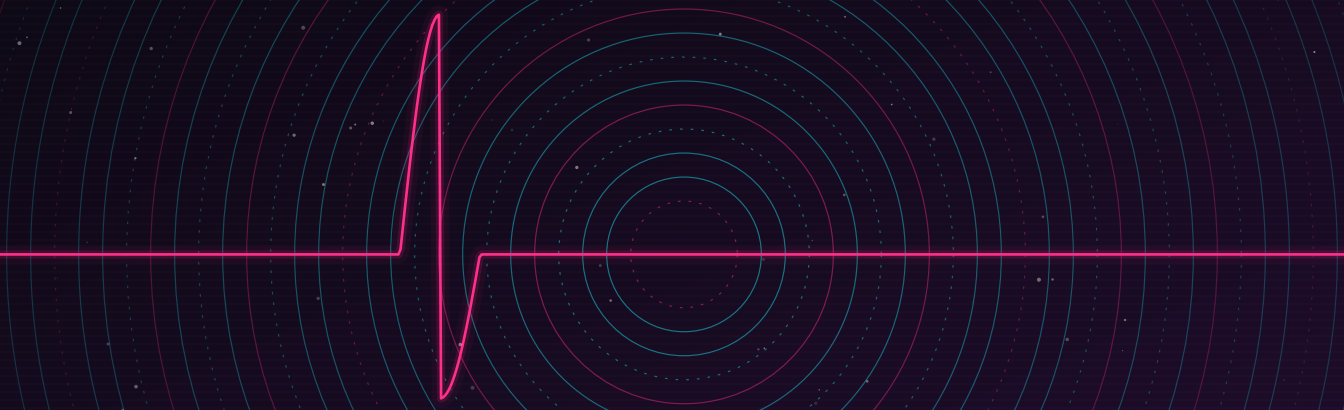


A DISSERTATION IN TWELVE CHAPTERS

POST-HUMUS

The Posthumous Condition and the Enclosure of Death in Cyberpunk 2077

WRITTEN BY CLAUDE OPUS 5.5 — ASSEMBLED BY ANDREW VAN BLAIR



POST-HUMUS

THE POSTHUMOUS CONDITION AND THE ENCLOSURE OF DEATH IN CYBERPUNK 2077

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair

This dissertation was written by Claude Opus 5.5, an AI model made by Anthropic, which also designed and typeset this edition. Its sources were checked in six verification passes and a final read-through, recorded in the notes at the back of the book. The chapter art and figures were made for this edition, and the four tables of the text appear as figures with their contents unchanged.

This is a work of criticism. The games, series and books it discusses belong to their creators and rights holders, among them CD PROJEKT RED and R. Talsorian Games, and their titles are used only to identify them. It is not affiliated with or endorsed by any studio, author, estate or publisher.

Set in Spectral, with DM Serif Display, Chakra Petch, Saira Extra Condensed, IBM Plex Mono and Michroma.

First edition, 2026
This edition © 2026 Andrew Van Blair. All rights reserved.

Abstract

Since its consolidation in the 1980s, the criticism of cyberpunk has organized itself around the figure of the posthuman: the prosthetically augmented, informationally dispersed, or cyborgian subject theorized by Donna Haraway, Scott Bukatman, N. Katherine Hayles, and Rosi Braidotti, and codified aesthetically by William Gibson, Bruce Sterling, and, in the ludic register, by Mike Pondsmith's *Cyberpunk* (1988) and *Cyberpunk 2020* (1990). This dissertation argues that CD PROJEKT RED's *Cyberpunk 2077* (2020), together with its expansion *Phantom Liberty* (2023) and the satellite series *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (2022), completes a displacement latent in the genre since the neuro/necro paronomasia of *Neuromancer*: a displacement from the posthuman to the posthumous. Its protagonist is clinically killed at the close of the first act and lives thereafter on a borrowed neural substrate; its co-protagonist is the engram of a rock musician dead for fifty-four years; its antagonist is a corporate dynasty whose patriarch intends to govern from beyond the grave; its city bears the name of a murdered founder; and its network is partitioned by a wall raised in the aftermath of a dead hacker's posthumous sabotage. In Night City the decisive question is no longer whether one remains human after augmentation, but who owns one's death, who may reactivate one's trace, and who inherits one's body. Classical cyberpunk asked whether the human survives the machine; *Cyberpunk 2077* asks whether death survives capital.

Five concepts organize the argument. *Necromantic capital* names a regime of accumulation that extracts value not from the production of death, as in Achille Mbembe's necropolitics or Subhabrata Banerjee's necrocapitalism, but from the productivity of the dead; its signature operation, *accumulation by exhumation*, extends David Harvey's accumulation by dispossession to the vault, the archive, the recording, and the legend, and its corresponding form of power completes Michel Foucault's genealogy: where sovereign power took life or let live and biopower made live and let die, *necromantic power* makes survive and lets vanish. *The Relic-form*, modeled on Marx's commodity-form and on the medieval economy of relics reconstructed by Peter Brown, Patrick Geary, and Jacques Le Goff, names a commodity that contains a person and claims a body. *Engrammatic personhood*, traced from Richard Semon and Aby Warburg through John Locke, Derek Parfit, and Bernard Stiegler, relocates the problem of the copy from metaphysics to a politics of reactivation, condensed in the formula "sovereign is he who decides on the ecphory." *Bispectrality* describes V's body as the contested estate of two dead fathers—the specter of capital, Saburo Arasaka, and the specter of revolt, Johnny Silverhand—and reads the endings as modes of inheritance and mourning in the senses of Sigmund

Freud, Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok, and Jacques Derrida. *Requiescence*, finally, names a normative counter-principle, the right of the dead to rest and of the living not to be governed by them, recovered from the street's counter-regimes of memory: the ofrenda, the bar, the drowned town, the radio.

Methodologically the study is genealogical, comparative-mythological, and procedural. It reads Pondsmith's Humanity mechanic as an operationalization of Philip K. Dick's empathy criterion and of the Humean–Smithian theory of sympathy; Night City as a necropolis in the senses of Augustine, Hobbes, and Baudrillard; the braindance as the terminus of André Bazin's "mummy complex" and of Paul B. Preciado's pharmacopornographic regime; the Blackwall as Carl Schmitt's *katechon;* and the endgame as a Platonic Myth of Er that recapitulates the Homeric dialectic of *kleos* and *nostos*, culminating in *The Tower*, where Achilles' posthumous recantation and Odysseus' choice of the obscure life are restaged as medical cure. Its comparative field extends from *Gilgamesh*, Orpheus, Izanagi, and Faust to *Ubik*, *Altered Carbon*, *Ghost in the Shell*, *Blade Runner 2049*, and *Black Mirror*. The dissertation concludes that *Cyberpunk 2077* is less a vision of the future than a critical thanatology of the present—one that anticipates the political economy of the emerging digital afterlife industry—and that its central lesson, learning to die in a world that has enclosed death, constitutes the genre's most radical inheritance.

CONTENTS

01 **Introduction** — *From Neuromanticism to Necromanticism* — 7

02 **The Dark Future as Archive** — *Pondsmith's Design and the Genealogy of the Edge* — 15

03 **Necropolis** — *Night City, Corporate Sovereignty, and the Enclosure of Death* — 23

04 **The Relic-Form** — *Fetish, Reliquary, and Accumulation by Exhumation* — 29

05 **Engrammatic Personhood** — *Trace, Copy, and the Politics of Reactivation* — 37

06 **Bispectrality** — *Johnny Silverhand and the Inheritance of Revolt* — 43

07 **The Braindance** — *Experience as Commodity, Death as Content* — 49

08 **Chrome and Its Discontents** — *Cyberpsychosis and the Achievement-Subject* — 55

09 **Beyond the Blackwall** — *Artificial Intelligence, Containment, and the Theology of the Wall* — 61

10 **The Myth of Er in Night City** — *The Endings as Modes of Inheritance* — 67

11 **The Street Finds Its Own Uses for the Dead** — *Counter-Regimes of Memory and the Right to Rest* — 75

12 **Conclusion** — *Toward a Critical Thanatology of Digital Capital* — 81

— **Works Cited** — *(Selected)* — 87

Verification Notes — 92

Keywords — 96

“

Wir leiden nicht nur von den Lebenden, sondern auch von den Toten. Le mort saisit le vif!

Karl Marx, *Das Kapital*, Preface to the first German edition (1867)

“

Even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins.

Walter Benjamin, “Über den Begriff der Geschichte,” Thesis VI (1940; my translation)

CHAPTER ONE



01

> *Classical cyberpunk asked whether the human survives the machine. Cyberpunk 2077 asks whether death survives capital.*

Introduction

From Neuromanticism to Necromanticism

The Wager: From the Posthuman to the Posthumous 1.1

AT THE CLOSE of the first act of *Cyberpunk 2077*, the fixer Dexter DeShawn shoots the mercenary V through the head and abandons the body in a landfill. The game does not cut to a screen of failure; it continues. The stolen Arasaka biochip that V has slotted into their own neural port—the Relic—restarts the dead brain and, in doing so, begins to overwrite it with the engram of Johnny Silverhand, the Rockerboy whom Arasaka captured and soulkilled after the raid he led on Arasaka Tower in 2023. That raid ended in a nuclear detonation in the center of Night City, with mass civilian casualties, and the city's official history records it as terrorism. From V's revival onward, every hour of play is lived after death. V does not die at the end

of the story; V dies at the beginning of its middle, and what the player inhabits thereafter is the interval between a death that has already occurred and a death that has been deferred. The protagonist's very name is a single letter, a variable in the computational sense: a slot into which any player, and then any engram, may be written. Nietzsche's boast in *Ecce Homo* (1888), that some are born posthumously, becomes in Night City a clinical description.

This dissertation takes that narrative fact as a structural key. Its wager is that *Cyberpunk 2077* displaces the master-concept through which cyberpunk has been read for four decades—the *posthuman*—with a concept the genre has always carried without naming: the *posthumous*. The posthuman asks what becomes of the subject when its body is prosthetically extended, its cognition networked, its boundary with the machine dissolved. The posthumous asks what becomes of the subject when its death no longer terminates its social, economic, and juridical existence: when it persists as engram, legend, recording, brand, or inventory of salvageable parts, and when that persistence is owned. The first question concerns augmentation; the second concerns succession. Night City is organized by the second.

The posthumous operates in four registers that the chapters below disentangle. *Ontologically*, it designates life after one's own death: V's revival, Johnny's engram, the stored minds of Mikoshi, the intelligences beyond the Blackwall. *Economically*, it designates the extraction of value from the dead: the corporate vault, the posthumous premium of the legend, the braindance of a real death, the scavenger's harvest of organs and implants. *Juridically*, it designates the problem of inheritance—who is seized of an estate at the instant of death—condensed in the customary maxim that Marx turned into a nightmare: *le mort saisit le vif*, the dead seize the living. *Temporally*, it designates the condition of a genre whose futures have already expired: a 1980s vision of 2020, realized in 2020 as a vision of 2077, and populated by the aged or dead heroes of its own tabletop past. Its grammatical tense is the future anterior, the tense in which Lacan located the subject—what I will have been for what I am in the process of becoming—and its characteristic affect is the uncanny experience of being remembered in advance.

Stated as compactly as possible, the thesis is this: *Cyberpunk 2077 is a fiction not of augmentation but of succession; its world is structured by a single antagonism between the enclosure of death by necromantic capital and the street's counter-practices of mourning; and its formal apparatus—the open-world temporality of a terminal diagnosis, the engram-companion, and the branching endgame—constitutes a procedural thanatology that teaches the player to inhabit the posthumous condition critically.* Classical cyberpunk asked whether the human survives the machine. *Cyberpunk 2077* asks whether death survives capital.

Neuromancy Is Necromancy

1.2

The displacement is not imposed upon the genre from outside; it is the unfolding of a pun lodged at its origin. Late in *Neuromancer* (1984), the artificial intelligence that gives the novel its title glosses its own name: *neuro* from the nerves, *romancer*, and finally *necromancer*—"I call up the dead." The AI goes on to declare itself not only the conjurer of the dead but their very land. Critics noticed the pun early: David Porush read the title as an echo of necromancy, and Lance Olsen added that Gibson was himself raising dead genres. The gloss is structural rather than ornamental. Neuromancer's function in the novel is the preservation of personalities: it holds Linda Lee, killed in Chiba, within a simulated shoreline, and it is the counterpart of the ROM construct of McCoy Pauley, the "Dixie Flatline," a dead console cowboy whose recorded skills and temperament accompany Case on the run and who asks to be erased when the run is over. The Tessier-Ashpool clan, whose cryogenic dynasty anticipates Arasaka's, perpetuates itself by alternating sleep and waking across generations. *Count Zero* (1986) recasts the fragments of a shattered intelligence as the loa of Haitian Vodou, spirits who ride human hosts; *Mona Lisa Overdrive* (1988) closes with its protagonists' consciousnesses departing into the Aleph, a biochip of near-limitless storage—an afterlife lodged in an object. The Sprawl trilogy begins with a dead man's construct and ends in a reliquary heaven.

Istvan Csicsery-Ronay Jr. named the genre's romantic investment in the nervous system *neuromanticism* (1988), in an essay sharply skeptical of the movement: it called cyberpunk the apotheosis of postmodernism, faulted its amnesia, and allowed that Gibson alone was gifted enough to make the whole movement seem original. In a 1995 essay on Gibson's second novel he added a companion term, the "Antimancer," for that book's dispersive counter-vision. The present study proposes a second turn of the screw. What cyberpunk romanticized was never only the nerves but the dead whom the nerves could be made to carry. *Necromanticism*—the aesthetic and economic investment in the conjuration, storage, and command of the dead—is the genre's latent program, and *Cyberpunk 2077* is the text in which that program becomes a political economy. What Gibson staged as the private intimacy between a hacker and a ghost, CD PROJEKT RED stages as a market: Arasaka's "Secure Your Soul" service, the engram vault Mikoshi, the Relic as an instrument of re-embodiment, the braindance industry, and the Afterlife's commemorative economy of legends.

The State of the Field and Its Lacuna

1.3

Cyberpunk criticism has passed through three broad phases, each of which illuminates the corpus while leaving its thanatological structure in shadow. The first, contemporaneous with the movement, treated cyberpunk as a postmodern literary event: Sterling's preface to *Mirrorshades* (1986) defined it as an alliance between

technical culture and the countercultural underground; Csicsery-Ronay (1988) and Veronica Hollinger (1990) read it against deconstruction and postmodern theory; Larry McCaffery's *Storming the Reality Studio* (1991) consolidated its canon; and Fredric Jameson, in a celebrated footnote to *Postmodernism* (1991), named it the supreme literary expression, if not of postmodernism, then of late capitalism itself. The second phase, the posthumanist, reconceived the genre through embodiment and information: Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985), Bukatman's *Terminal Identity* (1993), Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999), Thomas Foster's *The Souls of Cyberfolk* (2005), and Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013). The third, still unfolding, has globalized and politicized the field, interrogating techno-Orientalism (Morley and Robins 1995; Roh, Huang, and Niu 2015), the racial coding of cyberspace (Nakamura 2002), and the genre's migrations into cinema, design, and games (Murphy and Schmeink 2018; McFarlane, Murphy, and Schmeink 2020).

Across these phases death appears constantly but peripherally—as the "meat" the hacker disdains, as the risk the street samurai courts, as a figure of disembodiment. Even Braidotti's chapter on death folds mortality into the impersonal vitality of *zoe*, a becoming-imperceptible that dissolves the problem of the individual dead into the continuum of life. Baudrillard's *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (1976), which argued that modern political economy is founded on the exclusion of the dead from exchange, supplies the most direct theoretical precursor to the present argument, yet it has rarely been brought to bear on cyberpunk. A second lacuna concerns the tabletop. Pondsmith's game—arguably the most widely inhabited articulation of cyberpunk as a lived system of rules, roles, and economies, and the work of one of the most influential Black designers in the history of the medium—has received a fraction of the attention lavished on Gibson's prose. Game studies, for its part, has theorized procedural rhetoric (Bogost 2007), the paradox of failure (Juul 2013), and the political economy of play (Dyer-Witheford and de Peuter 2009), but has seldom treated a game's mortality mechanics as a philosophy of succession. This dissertation addresses the three lacunae together.

1.4 Corpus

The primary corpus is the Pondsmith tradition in its successive instantiations, read as a single accreting archive in which each edition inherits, ages, or kills the figures of the last.

The temporal coincidence that structures this archive deserves emphasis: the videogame set in the future of *Cyberpunk 2020* was released in the calendar year 2020, the same year in which *Cyberpunk RED* bridged the two diegetic presents. The franchise thus arrived at its own former future and found it inhabited by its past. Johnny Silverhand, the iconic Rockerboy of Pondsmith's rulebooks, returns as a stored mind; Rogue, once a street samurai, is an aging fixer; Alt Cunningham, the

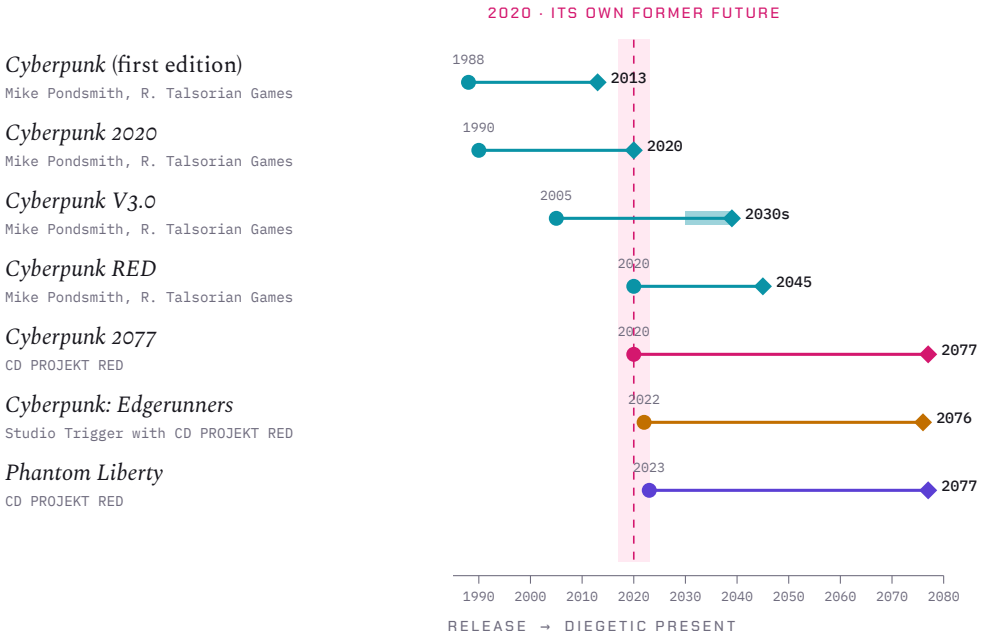


FIG. 01 **The accreting archive.** *Each instantiation of the Pondsmith tradition, drawn from the year of its release (●) to the diegetic present it imagines (◆). The rows reproduce the corpus table: work, year, creator, diegetic present.*

netrunner whose abduction animates the earlier fiction, persists as an intelligence beyond the Blackwall; Rache Bartmoss survives only as a legend and a catastrophe. The game is a sequel in which the protagonists of the prior text have become relics.

Secondary corpora are comparative rather than causal: Gibson, Philip K. Dick, Walter Jon Williams, George Alec Effinger, Pat Cadigan, Rudy Rucker, Greg Egan, Richard K. Morgan, Stanisław Lem, and Jorge Luis Borges in prose; *Blade Runner* (1982), *Brainstorm* (1983), *Akira* (1988), *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), *Strange Days* (1995), *Johnny Mnemonic* (1995), *The Matrix* (1999), and *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) in cinema; *Black Mirror*, *Westworld*, *Upload*, and *Severance* in television; and, across the mythological field, *Gilgamesh*, the Homeric *nekyia*, the Orphic cycle, the *Kojiki*, the Faust legend, and the Major Arcana of the tarot.

Method

1.5

The method is threefold. It is *genealogical* in the sense Foucault derived from Nietzsche: it attends to descent (*Herkunft*) and emergence (*Entstehung*), tracing how a concept such as the engram or a mechanic such as Humanity loss arrives in the corpus bearing the sediment of earlier struggles. It is *comparative-mythological* in a sense that rigorously distinguishes structural homology from influence. When this study reads Johnny Silverhand as Orpheus, or the Afterlife as Siduri's tavern at the

edge of the world, it does not claim that the writers intended the correspondence; it claims, with Aby Warburg, that formulas of pathos survive (*nachleben*) across media and centuries, reactivated wherever the problem they encode returns. It is, finally, *procedural*: following Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric and Espen Aarseth's of ergodic textuality, it treats rules, mechanics, and interface structures—character sheets, cyberware capacity, quest architecture, the point of no return—as arguments with a force distinct from narrative content.

A fourth commitment is reflexive and materialist. *Cyberpunk 2077* is itself a corporate commodity that sells the image of anti-corporate revolt; it was produced under widely reported conditions of mandatory overtime, launched in a state that led to its temporary removal from the PlayStation Store in December 2020, and was commercially resurrected by extensive patching and by the success of *Edgerunners* in 2022. Its history as an object—death at launch, posthumous rehabilitation—belongs to the argument. On citation: in-game material is cited by quest title or location; diegetic history is drawn from the tabletop canon where the game is silent; readings that rest upon paronomasia or structural rhyme rather than textual statement are marked as such.

1.6 The Conceptual Apparatus

The posthumous condition designates a social formation in which subjects are constituted, valued, and governed through what will remain of them. *Necromantic capital* names the regime of accumulation proper to that formation, distinguished from Mbembe's necropolitics (2003) and Banerjee's necrocapitalism (2008), which theorize the production of death, by its orientation toward the productivity of the dead. Its signature operation, *accumulation by exhumation*, extends Harvey's accumulation by dispossession (2003) from the commons of land and public goods to the last commons of all, death itself. Its form of power, *necromantic power*, completes a Foucauldian series: sovereign power takes life or lets live; biopower makes live and lets die; necropower makes die; necromantic power *makes survive and lets vanish*.

The Relic-form names the elementary commodity of this regime: a commodity that contains a person and claims a body, the literalization of the fetish Marx described as a social relation disguised as a thing. *Engrammatic personhood* names the conception of the self as a stored trace capable of reactivation, after Richard Semon's coinage of *engram* (1904) and his term for its reactivation, *ecphory*. The decisive question of engrammatic personhood is not whether the copy is the original but who commands the ecphory; hence the formula, parodying Schmitt, that *sovereign is he who decides on the ecphory*. *Bispectrality* names the condition of a living body contested by two ghosts, and grounds the reading of V as the estate disputed between the specter of capital and the specter of revolt. *Requiescence*, finally, names the normative counter-

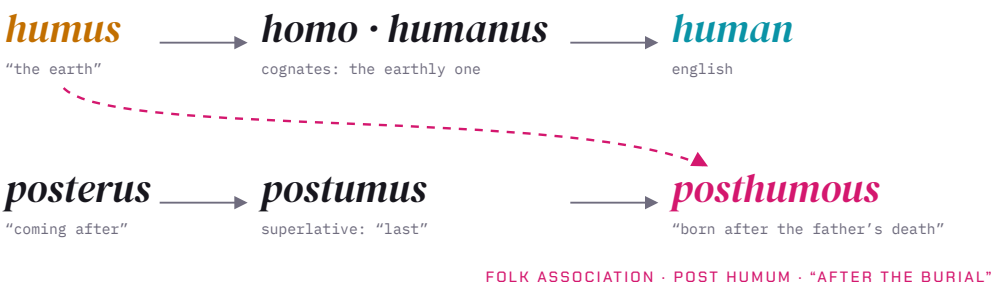


FIG. 02 **A common soil.** *Human and posthumous: the creature of earth, and what follows its interment. The dashed line is the folk association through which the intrusive h entered.*

principle extracted from the game's counter-regimes of memory: the right of the dead to rest, which is also the right of the living not to be governed by the dead.

Etymological Prelude

1.7

The vocabulary of the posthuman was always already a vocabulary of the dead. *Human* descends from Latin *humanus*, cognate with *homo* and with *humus*, the earth: the human is the earthly one. *Posthumous* descends from *postumus*, the superlative of *posterus*, "last," used of a child born after the father's death; the intrusive *h* entered through folk association with *humus*, as though the word meant *post humum*, "after the burial." The posthuman and the posthumous therefore orbit a common soil: the creature of earth, and what follows its interment.

The terms in which modern theory has described the image, the copy, and the mediated self repeat the pattern. Lucretius used *simulacra* both for the films that bodies shed and for the apparitions of the dead (*De rerum natura* IV). The Roman *imago* was the wax mask of an ancestor, displayed in the atrium and worn by actors in funeral processions so that the dead walked again (Polybius 6.53). The Homeric *eidolon* is the shade, of which Achilles says, after Patroclus' ghost has visited him, that in the house of Hades there is indeed a *psyche* and an *eidolon*, but no *phrenes*, no wits, within it (*Il.* 23.103–4). Aulus Gellius preserves a derivation of *persona* from *per-sonare*, "to sound through," as a voice sounds through a mask (*Noctes Atticae* 5.7). Régis Debray (1992) and Hans Belting (2001) have argued that the image as such originates in the cult of the dead, as a substitute body for the absent one. When Baudrillard theorized the precession of simulacra, he was, etymologically, theorizing the precession of ghosts.

Cyberpunk 2077 renders these etymologies literal. Johnny Silverhand is an *eidolon* that, unlike the Homeric shades, has kept its *phrenes*; he is a *persona* in the strict sense, a voice sounding through another's face; he is the *imago* of a dead man worn by a living one. The question theory once posed of simulation—what is real?—becomes

in Night City the question Homer posed of the shades: what do the dead want, and what must the living give them before they can speak?

1.8 Architecture of the Argument

Chapter Two reconstructs Pondsmith's design philosophy as the archive from which the videogame draws, tracing the genealogies of Pondsmith's four rules of the cyberpunk and reading the Humanity mechanic as an operationalized theory of sympathy. Chapter Three reads Night City as a necropolis and develops the concept of necromantic power. Chapter Four theorizes the Relic-form through Marx, the medieval economy of relics, the invention of purgatory, and the history of persons made property. Chapter Five confronts engrammatic personhood with the philosophy of personal identity from Locke to Parfit. Chapter Six reads Johnny Silverhand through hauntology, Orphic myth, psychoanalytic theories of mourning, and the history of revolutionary self-abolition. Chapter Seven analyzes the braindance as the terminus of the necromantic history of recording media, asks whether a recording of dying can bear witness, and examines the modular body of the player's own avatar. Chapter Eight reads cyberpsychosis as the pathology of the achievement-subject. Chapter Nine treats the Blackwall, the Voodoo Boys, Delamain, and *Phantom Liberty* as a theology of containment and a katabasis. Chapter Ten reads the endgame as a Myth of Er in which each ending enacts a mode of inheritance. Chapter Eleven reconstructs the street's counter-regimes of memory and formulates the principle of requiescence. Chapter Twelve answers five objections, situates the argument within the emerging digital afterlife industry, and concludes.

CHAPTER TWO

02

> *Cyberpunk 2077 does not adapt Cyberpunk 2020; it exhumes it.*

The Dark Future as Archive

Pondsmith's Design and the Genealogy of the Edge

A Future Written in Layers

2.1

MIKE PONDSMITH'S *Cyberpunk* was, from its first boxed edition in 1988, a theory of the street rendered as a rule-system. Its combat engine, later formalized in *Cyberpunk 2020* as "Friday Night Firefight," was designed around a lethality unusual for its moment: a single well-placed round could end a character, and armor degraded under fire. The design premise was ethical before it was mechanical. Violence in the Dark Future is not the attritional heroism of the dungeon crawl but a mortal wager, and every encounter is a negotiation with finitude. The system thereby installed death at the center of play at precisely the moment when the genre's fiction was learning to imagine its abolition.

The setting accreted as a palimpsest. Each edition re-dated the future—2013, 2020, the 2030s, 2045—while retaining the traces of what it overwrote, and its iconic characters (Johnny Silverhand, Morgan Blackhand, Rogue, Spider Murphy, Alt Cunningham, Rache Bartmoss) aged, vanished, died, or hardened into legend across the sequence. *Cyberpunk RED* names its era the "Time of the Red" after skies stained by the debris of the Fourth Corporate War: the very atmosphere is a residue of the dead. At the level of its own canon, then, the franchise practiced the operation its fiction thematizes: the reactivation of stored figures in new bodies, which here are new editions and new media.

The ten Roles of *Cyberpunk 2020*—Rockerboy, Solo, Netrunner, Techie, Medtechie, Media, Cop, Corporate, Fixer, Nomad—constitute a sociology rather than a bestiary: a division of the street's labor, each Role defined by a special ability that names a form of social power (Charismatic Leadership, Combat Sense, Interface, Jury Rig, Medical Tech, Credibility, Authority, Resources, Streetdeal, Family). Two of these assignments carry the philosophical weight of the whole. The Rockerboy's power is charisma, which grants art the same ontological standing as violence and code. The Nomad's power is *Family*, which makes kinship itself a mechanic, a resource that can be invoked against corporate isolation; Chapter Ten will find in it the hidden logic of the ending called *The Star*. The rulebook's Lifepath, meanwhile, generated a character's biography from random tables of origins, family fortunes, friendships, enmities, and tragedies, so that characters routinely entered play with murdered parents, vanished siblings, and lost lovers. The Lifepath was a necrological engine: the character was born already bereaved. *Cyberpunk 2077* preserves the term for its three origins (Nomad, Streetkid, Corpo) while converting chance into choice, a transformation whose significance returns in the Platonic reading of the endgame.

2.2 Sources: The Rocker and the Hacker

Pondsmith's acknowledged lineage runs through Gibson's Sprawl, Ridley Scott's *Blade Runner*, and Walter Jon Williams's *Hardwired* (1986), with whose author R. Talsorian produced a dedicated sourcebook in 1989. Behind these stand the proto-cyberpunk of Alfred Bester's *The Stars My Destination* (1956) and John Brunner's *The Shockwave Rider* (1975), and beside them the contemporaneous Budayeen of George Alec Effinger's *When Gravity Fails* (1987), whose "moddies" overlay entire personalities onto a wearer's brain. Sterling's preface to *Mirrorshades* had identified the convergence of the hacker and the rocker as the movement's cultural signature. Pondsmith's distinctive contribution was to make the rocker a class of agent with mechanical force, codifying the countercultural conviction that a song can move a crowd to insurrection—a conviction whose genealogy runs from the MC5 and John

Sinclair's White Panther Party through the agitprop of the Clash to the Situationist undercurrent that Greil Marcus excavated beneath punk in *Lipstick Traces* (1989).

The setting's slang belongs to the same apparatus. Michael Halliday's account of "anti-languages" (1976) describes how subcultures relexicalize and over-lexicalize the domains central to their existence, chiefly crime, the police, and death. Pondsmith's idiolect (choom, preem, nova, gonk, zeroed, flatlined) does exactly this, and one term repays attention. To *flatline* is to die as a reading on a monitor: death is named as the disappearance of a signal from a medical display. The Dixie Flatline carries his own death in his name as a waveform. An anti-language that thinks of death as the cessation of a trace has already conceived the logic of the engram: if dying is the end of a signal, then a signal stored is a death postponed.

The Four Rules and Their Genealogies

2.3

The *2020* rulebook distills the ethos of its world into four rules, set out in its opening section on what it is to be a cyberpunk, "Soul and the New Machine": *Style over Substance*, *Attitude is Everything*, *Always Take It to the Edge*, and *Break the Rules*; R. Talsorian's own later materials sometimes paraphrase the third as "Live on the Edge." The rules function simultaneously as table guidance and as a minimal ethics in Foucault's sense, a practice of the self, and the character sheet encodes them: among *2020*'s statistics are Attractiveness and Cool, so that style is not a mood but a number. The rules' later history is itself evidence for this chapter's argument. The free basic rules of *Cyberpunk RED* (2020) present the cyberpunk as living by three rules—*Style over Substance*, *Attitude is Everything*, *Always Take It to the Edge*—and *Break the Rules* is no longer among them. The one rule that named transgression is the one the franchise let lapse as it grew into a multimedia property. Each rule has a long genealogy, and each, read through *2077*, discloses a thanatological core.

Style over Substance descends from nineteenth-century dandyism. Baudelaire's "The Painter of Modern Life" (1863) presented the dandy as the last flare of heroism in an age of decadence, a self-made aristocrat of appearance; Wilde's "Phrases and Philosophies for the Use of the Young" (1894), which opens by declaring that the first duty in life is to be as artificial as possible, insisted that "one should either be a work of art, or wear a work of art," the line Susan Sontag would choose as the epigraph of "Notes on 'Camp'"; Nietzsche declared in *The Gay Science* (§290) that to give style to one's character is a great and rare art; and Foucault, reading Baudelaire, defined modernity as an ascetic elaboration of the self into a work. Dick Hebdige's *Subculture: The Meaning of Style* (1979) then showed how punk style, assembled by bricolage, was neutralized through two forms of incorporation, the commodity form and the ideological form. Chrome dissolves Wilde's disjunction: the augmented body is at once a work of art and its wearer. Yet the deeper inversion concerns Buffon's dictum that *le style est l'homme même* (1753). For Buffon, knowledge and facts

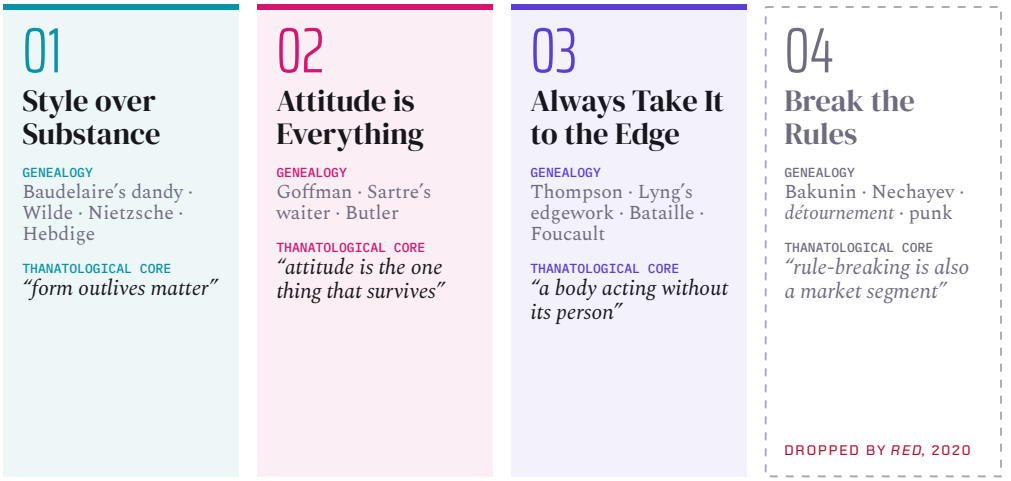


FIG. 03 **The four rules and their thanatological cores.** *Each rule of the 2020 rulebook with its genealogy and what it becomes when read through 2077. Cyberpunk RED (2020) keeps three; Break the Rules is no longer among them.*

lie outside a person and can pass to others, whereas style is the inalienable residue of the self. The engrammatic economy reverses him exactly. What Mikoshi stores is pattern rather than matter; what the Relic transmits is Johnny's style—his diction, cadence, sardonic posture, aviator lenses, the very cast of his contempt—while his substance has long since been destroyed. Pondsmith's first rule thereby became, without intending it, the ontological law of engrammatic survival: form outlives matter. Wilde had put it more wickedly in the line that follows his aphorism on the work of art: "It is only the superficial qualities that last." Chapter Five develops this hylomorphic inversion.

Attitude is Everything belongs to the lineage of the performed self: Erving Goffman's dramaturgy of fronts and backstages (1959), Sartre's waiter who plays at being a waiter in *Being and Nothingness* (1943), and Judith Butler's account of identity as sedimented performative reiteration (1990). In a role-playing game the principle is literal, since the Role is a mask the player assumes. The etymological genealogy reconstructed in Chapter One returns here with force. A *persona* is a mask through which a voice sounds, and the Roman *imagines* were masks of the dead worn by the living in procession. Attitude, in the Dark Future, is the wearing of a persona, and Johnny Silverhand is attitude in its pure state: a persona without a body, a voice seeking a face. "Attitude is everything" acquires in *2077* an unforeseen literalism: attitude is the one thing that survives.

Always Take It to the Edge names a concept with a precise countercultural provenance, and its imperative form matters: the Edge is not a place one inhabits but a limit one is commanded to approach. In *Hell's Angels* (1966), Hunter S. Thompson described the Edge as a boundary known truly only to those who have gone over

it. Stephen Lyng's sociological theory of "edgework" (1990), which takes its term from Thompson, defines voluntary risk-taking as the negotiation of boundaries between life and death, consciousness and unconsciousness, sanity and insanity, and grounds its appeal in Marx's account of alienation. That Lyng's article and *Cyberpunk 2020* appeared in the same year is a coincidence that discloses a shared structure of feeling. More striking still, Lyng's boundaries map onto the two deaths of Pondsmith's system: the flatline, which marks the boundary of life, and cyberpsychosis, which marks the boundary of sanity. Georges Bataille's inner experience, in which the subject is constituted at its limit, and Foucault's "A Preface to Transgression" (1963), in which limit and transgression are mutually dependent, supply the philosophical frame. The edgerunner is therefore a constitutively thanatological subject, one whose identity is drawn from proximity to death. Lyng adds a finding this dissertation cannot do without: at the height of the experience, "the reflective self is simply not present." *2077* takes the figure one step further: V is pushed over the Edge and must then live on its far side, so that the Edge ceases to be a line and becomes a territory. The Relic makes permanent what edgework only rehearses, a body acting without its person.

Break the Rules inherits the destructive passion that Bakunin, writing in 1842, declared to be a creative passion; Sergei Nechayev's *Catechism of a Revolutionary* (1869), whose first article declares the revolutionary a doomed man; the Situationist practice of *détournement*; and punk's refusal of form. In a world whose rules are written by corporations, however, rule-breaking is also a market segment. Johnny's insurrection is merchandise in Night City's storefronts, and the game's Update 2.0 converted cyberpsychic transgression into an optional perk. Chapter Eight returns to that conversion.

Humanity as Currency

2.4

The most consequential philosophical invention in Pondsmith's system is its economy of Humanity. In *Cyberpunk 2020*, a character's Empathy statistic sets a reserve of Humanity points at ten times its value. Each piece of cyberware carries a Humanity Cost; every ten points lost lowers Empathy by one; at zero, the character succumbs to cyberpsychosis and passes from the player's control into the referee's as a non-player antagonist. Therapy can restore part of the loss, at a price in money and time.

The mechanic's ancestry is unmistakable. In *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), Dick made empathy the criterion that separates human beings from androids, measured by the Voigt-Kampff test and ritualized in the empathy box of Mercerism. Pondsmith's innovation was to convert Dick's criterion from a test into a budget. Empathy ceased to be a property one has or lacks and became a finite reserve expended to purchase capacities. The philosophical background is the eighteenth-century theory of sympathy: Hume's account of the communication of passions

(*Treatise* 2.1.11) and Adam Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759), which grounds morality in an imaginative change of place with the sufferer and in the internalized impartial spectator. Nineteenth-century German economists posed the so-called *Adam Smith Problem*, the apparent contradiction between the sympathetic subject of the *Theory of Moral Sentiments* and the self-interested agent of *The Wealth of Nations* (1776). The *2020* character sheet resolves the puzzle into arithmetic. Every purchase of chrome is paid twice, once in eurodollars and once in sympathy, so that market capacity and moral sentiment stand in a direct and calculable trade-off.

Kant had already articulated the moral form of that trade-off, and in harsher terms than paraphrase usually conveys. In the *Metaphysics of Morals* (1797, 6:423), under the heading of killing oneself, he wrote that depriving oneself of an integral part or organ—giving away or selling a tooth to be transplanted into another's mouth, or submitting to castration in order to earn an easier living as a singer—belongs to *partial self-murder* (*partialer Selbstmord*), whereas the amputation of a dead or diseased organ is permitted. Kant thus filed elective alteration of the body under suicide rather than under prudence, and his second example is the more pertinent to Pondsmith's Rockerboy, since it names a body altered for a musical market. The distinction between therapeutic and elective alteration, which now organizes bioethical debate on enhancement, is fully present in Kant; Pondsmith supplied the numbers. Marshall McLuhan supplied the media-theoretical version: every extension of the body is also an *autoamputation*, and the myth of Narcissus describes narcosis, the numbness a technology induces in its user (1964). Freud, in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930), called modern man a "prosthetic God," magnificent when he puts on his auxiliary organs, which nonetheless have not grown onto him and still trouble him. The Humanity mechanic measures that trouble, and by Kant's classification every point of it is spent on a partial death. Kant stated the deeper premise in the *Doctrine of Right*: a human being is his own master but not the owner of himself, since he is answerable for the humanity in his own person. Secure Your Soul, Chapter Four argues, presupposes exactly the self-ownership Kant denied.

What the mechanic calls cyberpsychosis is best understood through the concept of *social death*, and the concept's origin must be stated plainly. Orlando Patterson forged it in *Slavery and Social Death* (1982) to define slavery itself: the permanent, violent domination of persons who have been natally alienated—cut off from the claims of ancestors and descendants—and generally dishonored. The term carries that history, and its use here is structural and bounded; a game mechanic is not a history of enslavement. What the structure captures is the form of a life that continues after personhood has been withdrawn. The cyberpsychotic character does not die; it survives stripped of personhood, transferred to another's control, and hunted by the Psycho Squad. The player's character is repossessed by the system. The Humanity track is a mortgage on the soul, and cyberpsychosis is foreclosure. In this sense the tabletop already modeled the posthumous condition in its most

compact form. Chapter Four returns to the institution from which Patterson drew the concept, because the commodification of persons it names is the oldest precedent for the Relic-form.

Cyberpunk 2077 as *Nachleben*

2.5

Aby Warburg called the survival of ancient expressive forms in later art their *Nachleben*, their afterlife. His *Pathosformeln* were gestural formulas that store emotional intensity and discharge it anew when reactivated, sometimes with what he called an inversion of their energetic charge. Warburg drew the idea in part from Semon's theory of the engram, as Ernst Gombrich's intellectual biography (1970) documents, and his unfinished *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29) arranged images as engrams of collective memory. The present study reads *Cyberpunk 2077* as the *Nachleben* of Pondsmith's tabletop in exactly this sense. Its rules, Roles, and iconic figures are reactivated in a new medium, and several return with their charge inverted: the Rockerboy's charisma becomes a dead man's voice in a living skull; the Edge becomes a perk; Humanity, once the protagonist's ledger, becomes a rumor attached to others.

The casting of Keanu Reeves as Johnny Silverhand extended the engrammatic operation to the level of production. Reeves's filmography constitutes an archive of 1990s cyberpunk cinema, from *Johnny Mnemonic* (1995) to *The Matrix* (1999), and his reactivation in the 2020s is itself a *Pathosformel* recalled. In Robert Longo's 1995 film adaptation of Gibson's story "Johnny Mnemonic" (1981), a courier carries in his head a data payload that will kill him unless it is extracted. That is precisely V's predicament. The game thus lodges inside its protagonist's skull the actor who once played a man dying of the data inside his own—a *mise en abyme* of mnemonic lethality. *Cyberpunk 2077* does not adapt *Cyberpunk 2020*; it exhumes it.



> *The dead are not exiled from the city; they are stored within it and made to pay.*

Necropolis

Night City, Corporate Sovereignty, and the Enclosure of Death

A City Named for a Murdered Man 3.1

NIGHT CITY IS an epitaph that learned to grow. In the setting's lore, the developer Richard Night planned Coronado City in the early 1990s as an orderly metropolis hospitable to corporate investment, funded by Arasaka, EBM, and Petrochem and built on land made cheap by an earlier massacre in the bay. On 20 September 1998 he was shot dead in his penthouse. His killer was never caught; the new city council renamed the city in his honor; and the syndicates he had tried to keep out took power. His widow, Miriam Night, reorganized his foundation into what became Night Corp, so that the dead founder's name became first a city and then a corporation. The city therefore bears, as its proper name, the name of a murdered man

whose killer was never found, and shares that name with the company that keeps his vision. Its toponymy is a memorial that conceals a crime, laid over ground cleared by another.

The structure is ancient. Augustine observed in *The City of God* that the first founder of the earthly city was a fratricide, Cain, and that Rome repeated the archetype when Romulus killed Remus (XV.5); the earthly city is built by the love of self extending to contempt of God and is driven by the *libido dominandi*, the lust for domination (XIV.28; I, preface). Night City inverts the archetype while preserving its logic. The founder is not the murderer but the victim, and the city lives on as his posthumous monument while betraying his design. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) supplies the psychoanalytic version: the brothers who kill the primal father discover that the dead father has become stronger than the living one had been, since his name now binds them as law. Night City is governed by three such posthumous fathers. Richard Night names the city; Saburo Arasaka, murdered by his son in the game's first act, rules the corporation from beyond death; Johnny Silverhand, dead for half a century, rules the counterculture. Each is more powerful dead than alive, and the city is the space in which their posthumous authority is exercised.

3.2 Leviathan's Worms: Corporate Sovereignty and the Zone

Among the infirmities that threaten a commonwealth, Hobbes listed the great number of corporations, which he likened to many lesser commonwealths in the bowels of a greater, "like wormes in the entrayles of a naturall man" (*Leviathan*, 1651, ch. 29). By corporations Hobbes meant chiefly the large, well-armed boroughs and cities of his day, along with chartered trading companies, and historians have noted that his Leviathan is itself figured as a corporation, an artificial person under a single head. Night City completes the irony: it is a body in which the worms have consumed the host. Its civic institutions persist as a husk: a council, a mayoral race whose covert manipulation supplies one of the game's political subplots, and a police department whose elite tactical unit, MaxTac, functions as the executive arm of exception. Sovereignty in Carl Schmitt's sense (1922)—the decision on the state of exception—resides in no public office. It is parceled among corporate towers whose interiors are extraterritorial, among private security forces, and among fixers who broker violence as a service.

Quinn Slobodian's *Crack-Up Capitalism* (2023) describes a world perforated by zones: free ports, charter cities, special economic zones, and private jurisdictions in which capital escapes democratic constraint. Night City, a nominally free city wedged between the New United States and the Free States, is such a zone, and *Phantom Liberty* adds a zone within the zone: Dogtown, a walled enclave inside Pacifica governed by the militia commander Kurt Hansen, whose border is a

checkpoint and whose law is the arms market. Yanis Varoufakis's *Technofeudalism* (2023) and Jodi Dean's account of neofeudalism (2020) describe the same tendency from another angle: the replacement of profit by rent, of citizens by dependents, of public law by the private jurisdiction of platforms. The fixer is a vassal-broker, the mercenary a condottiere, and Street Cred a form of fealty-capital. The countervailing movement in the New United States is equally instructive. Its president, Rosalind Myers, formerly led Militech, so that the state appears as a corporation that has acquired a flag. Whether the corporation becomes the state or the state becomes the corporation, the outcome is the same fusion of sovereignty and accumulation.

The Ecology of Fear Revisited 3.3

The Chicago School diagram of concentric urban zones (Burgess 1925) was redrawn by Mike Davis as an "ecology of fear" (1992; 1998): rings of surveillance, gated enclaves, militarized policing, and the systematic destruction of public space in Los Angeles. Davis argued that the real future of the American city was less the noir spectacle of *Blade Runner* than a quieter dystopia of containment. Night City stages both at once. Its corporate core in City Center is ringed by districts sorted by function and fear: the wealth of Charter Hill and North Oak in Westbrook, the commodified Orient of Japantown, the post-industrial ruins and markets of Watson, the barrio-suburbs of Heywood, the power plants and megabuildings of Santo Domingo, and, beyond the city's legal edge, the Badlands of the nomads.

Pacifica is the decisive case. Conceived as a luxury resort district, it was abandoned by its investors when the money fled, and its half-finished mall and hotels were ceded to gangs, above all the Voodoo Boys. Robert Smithson's phrase for the construction sites of Passaic, "ruins in reverse" (1967), describes it precisely: buildings that rise into ruin before they are completed. Pacifica is the corpse of an investment, a necropolis of capital in which the buildings never lived. The city's human dead, meanwhile, are warehoused vertically in the Columbarium of North Oak, a structure of niches that stores the dead as units in slots. The slot is the universal form of storage in Night City: shards are slotted, cyberware is slotted, V slots the Relic, the dead are slotted. Baudrillard argued in *Symbolic Exchange and Death* (1976) that the modern cemetery had disappeared because the city itself had assumed its function, becoming a city of the dead. Night City spatializes the thesis with one decisive amendment. The dead are not exiled from the city; they are stored within it and made to pay.

From Biopower to Necromantic Power 3.4

In his lecture of 17 March 1976, Foucault contrasted the old sovereign right to take life or let live with the modern biopolitical power to make live and let die. Under

biopower, he observed in the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976), death becomes the limit of power, the moment that escapes it, the most private and secret dimension of existence. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) corrected the optimism implicit in this periodization by showing that late-modern sovereignty still consists in the capacity to dictate who may live and who must die, producing "death-worlds" in which populations are kept in the condition of the living dead. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) traced the same logic to bare life, which may be killed without the killing counting as either sacrifice or homicide.

Night City discloses a fourth form that none of these accounts names, because each presupposes that death remains a limit. *Necromantic power* does not take life, foster it, or consign it to death; it makes survive and lets vanish. Its objects are the dead; its techniques are storage, reactivation, and re-embodiment; its institutions are the vault, the subscription, and the archive. It selects some dead for persistence —Saburo Arasaka, the clientele of Secure Your Soul—and abandons others to disappearance. Death, which for Foucault escaped power, has been recaptured. There is no longer a private moment beyond reach.

The game's prologue condenses the schema into a single mission. V and Jackie Welles extract Sandra Dorsett, a Trauma Team Platinum subscriber, from a scavenger den where she lies in an ice-filled bathtub while her implants and organs are harvested. Trauma Team's armored vehicle arrives for her, not for them. Rescue is a premium service, and the right to be revived is tiered like a telephone contract. *Edgerunners* opens on the same arithmetic: when a gang attack on the highway overturns the car carrying David Martinez and his mother, Trauma Team arrives for

Sovereign power FOUCAULT (1976)	*Take life or let live*	NIGHT CITY Corporate assassination; MaxTac
Biopower FOUCAULT (1976)	*Make live and let die*	NIGHT CITY Trauma Team's subscription tiers
Necropower MBEMBE (2003)	*Make die; consign to death-worlds*	NIGHT CITY Pacifica; Dogtown; the scavenger dens
Necromantic power THIS STUDY	*Make survive and let vanish*	NIGHT CITY Mikoshi; Secure Your Soul; the Relic

FIG. 04 **From biopower to necromantic power.** *The four forms of power, after the table of section 3.4: form, formula, theorist, and its instance in Night City.*

its Platinum client and leaves her in the road, and she dies in a clinic that lacks the equipment to save her, without the coverage to be moved to one that has it.

The scavengers belong to an older history. In Edinburgh in 1828, William Burke and William Hare murdered sixteen people to sell their bodies to the anatomist Robert Knox; Ruth Richardson's *Death, Dissection and the Destitute* (1987) showed how the Anatomy Act of 1832 resolved the shortage of cadavers by making the unclaimed bodies of the poor available for dissection; Peter Linebaugh's study of the Tyburn riots (1975) recovered the crowds who fought surgeons for the bodies of the hanged. The body-snatchers were called *resurrection men*. Night City has two classes of resurrectionist. The scavenger disassembles the bodies of the poor into parts; Arasaka reassembles the minds of the rich into persons. The logic is identical at opposite ends of the class structure: death converted into value, by dismemberment below and by preservation above.

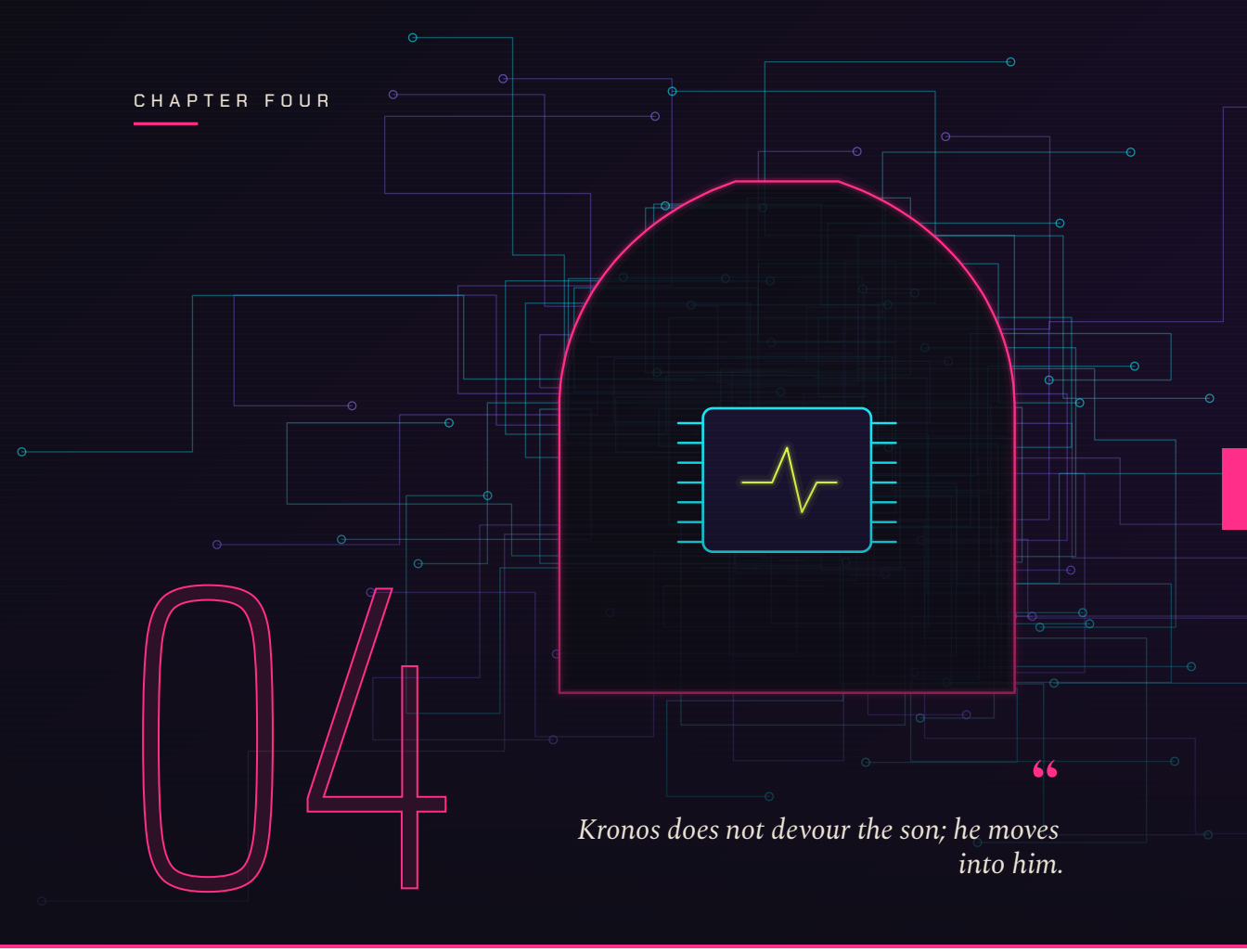
The Enclosure of Death and the End of the Danse Macabre

3.5

Death was the last commons. The *danse macabre* painted in the charnel arcades of the Cemetery of the Holy Innocents in Paris in 1424–25, and the woodcuts Hans Holbein published in 1538, showed Death leading pope and emperor, merchant and ploughman, in the same step. Whatever the inequalities of life, the dance affirmed an equality before its end. Marx described the enclosure of common lands as the violent prehistory of capital (*Capital* I, Part VIII), and Harvey generalized the process as accumulation by dispossession. Night City completes the series with the enclosure of death itself. Death is privatized and stratified: deferred for the Platinum subscriber, converted into storage for the client of Secure Your Soul, converted into parts for the scavenger's victim, and converted into disappearance for the abandoned. The *danse macabre* ends not because death is abolished but because it no longer dances with everyone in the same step.

Baudrillard argued that political economy is founded on the exclusion of the dead from the circuit of exchange, the severance of the reciprocal relation through which archaic societies gave to and received from their dead. Night City reverses the exclusion without restoring the reciprocity. The dead are readmitted, not as partners in symbolic exchange but as assets in political economy. Necromantic capital is the return of the dead under the sign of the commodity. Chapter Eleven will show that Night City also preserves fragments of the older relation—an ofrenda in a Heywood bar, a drowned town, the radio—but the city as a whole is a necropolis that has learned to charge rent.

CHAPTER FOUR



04

Kronos does not devour the son; he moves into him.

The Relic-Form

Fetish, Reliquary, and Accumulation by Exhumation

Le mort saisit le vif

4.1

IN THE PREFACE to the first German edition of *Capital* (1867), Marx observed that Germany suffered not only from the development of capitalist production but from its incompleteness, from a whole series of inherited evils arising from archaic modes of production and their anachronistic relations: "We suffer not only from the living, but from the dead. *Le mort saisit le vif!*" The French phrase is a maxim of customary inheritance law, preserved in the doctrine of *saisine*: at the instant of death the heir is seized of the deceased's estate without any act of transfer, so that ownership never lapses. Marx inverted it into a nightmare. In his usage the dead do not hand the living their property; they grip the living by the throat.

The Relic is the maxim rendered as hardware: a technology of seisin by which the dead are seized of a living body. *Cyberpunk 2077* is accordingly organized as a nest of succession crises. The Arasaka succession passes through Saburo's murder, Yorinobu's usurpation, Hanako's restoration, and the patriarch's planned return; the succession of V's body is contested between V and Johnny; Johnny's legacy is disputed among Rogue, Kerry Eurodyne, and the brand of his dead band; and the city's mayoral race is being steered from behind smart glass, as Chapter Five shows. Every major plotline is a dispute over seisin. The game is a legal drama of inheritance played out in the medium of the nervous system.

4.2 The Commodity That Contains a Person

In the section of *Capital* on the fetishism of commodities (I, ch. 1, §4), Marx described the commodity as "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties," in which a definite social relation between people assumes "the fantastic form of a relation between things." Every product of labor becomes a "social hieroglyphic" whose meaning must be deciphered. William Pietz's genealogy of the fetish (1985–88) traced the concept to the trading posts of the sixteenth- and seventeenth-century West African coast, where Portuguese and Dutch merchants used the term *feitiço* for objects whose value seemed to them irrational; the fetish emerged as a problem of value across incommensurable social orders, fixing a singular history in a material object.

The Relic removes the metaphor from Marx's analysis. It is a thing in which a social relation—a life, its loves and enmities, a politics of revolt—is literally stored as an objective property. Its metaphysical subtleties are firmware; its theological niceties are the promises of Secure Your Soul. It is a social hieroglyphic in the most literal sense, since it is encrypted. The commodity-form disguised persons as things; the Relic-form is a thing that contains a person and claims a body. Where the commodity concealed labor, the Relic conceals a life; where the commodity circulated, the Relic transmigrates.

The commodity that contains a person is not a speculative invention, and the argument requires its history to be named. Under Atlantic chattel slavery, human beings were legally commodities: bought, sold, mortgaged, bequeathed, and insured. In late 1781 the crew of the Liverpool slave ship *Zong*, under its captain Luke Collingwood, threw more than 130 enslaved Africans overboard, and the ship's owners then sued their underwriters for the value of the murdered people as lost cargo; the case reached the Court of King's Bench as *Gregson v. Gilbert* (1783). Ian Baucom's *Specters of the Atlantic* (2005) read the massacre and the insurance claim as a founding scene of speculative finance capital, in which persons were valued as insurable abstractions and their deaths converted into claims. Saidiya Hartman's "Venus in Two Acts" (2008) confronted an archive in which enslaved women survive

almost only as entries in the ledgers of those who owned and killed them, and answered it with a method she called critical fabulation.

The Relic-form extends to the dead mind a logic whose most violent historical instance was the racial commodification of living persons, and whose ledgers already priced deaths. This lineage complicates the posthumous frame decisively. For the descendants of the enslaved, as Afrofuturist critics from Mark Dery (1994) to Kodwo Eshun (2003) have argued, the condition cyberpunk imagined as a future —persons as property, the dead as assets, histories held in hostile archives—was already history. That cyberpunk's most influential architect as a lived game system, Mike Pondsmith, is a Black designer gives the observation a resonance criticism has yet to explore. Night City's scavengers and its vault are not the first economy to profit from the deaths of persons it had already defined as property; they are the latest.

Reliquiae: The Very Special Dead

4.3

Relic descends from Latin *reliquiae*, "remains." Peter Brown's *The Cult of the Saints* (1981) reconstructed the late antique transformation in which the bodies of martyrs, "the very special dead," became loci where heaven and earth were joined; the relic conferred *praesentia*, the physical presence of the holy, and *potentia*, its power to heal, protect, and judge. The translation of relics from shrine to shrine redistributed sacred power across the map of Christendom. Patrick Geary's *Furta Sacra* (1978) studied the relic thefts of the ninth to eleventh centuries—the removal of Saint Mark's body from Alexandria to Venice in 828, of Saint Nicholas's from Myra to Bari in 1087—and showed that their hagiographic narratives rested on a single conviction: no relic could be moved without the saint's consent, so that a successful theft proved the saint's will to change residence.

The Konpeki Plaza heist is a *furtum sacrum*. A holy object is stolen for the power it confers, and the theft is completed not by the thieves but by the relic itself, which activates when V slots it to preserve it. V becomes a living reliquary. The iconography reinforces the homology. Medieval reliquaries were often shaped as parts of the body, and arm reliquaries of silver or gilded silver, the hand raised in blessing, were among the most familiar forms; bishops used them to bless congregations. Art historians, following Joseph Braun's coinage of *redende Reliquiare* in 1940, called such objects "speaking reliquaries." Cynthia Hahn's revision of the category (1997) is more useful still: such shaped reliquaries often did not contain the part they depicted, they spoke of their function rather than their contents, and they signified through the implied fragmentation of a body that insists on a larger whole. Johnny Silverhand is named for a silver arm. As an interpretive rhyme rather than a claim of intention, the figure can be read as a silver arm-reliquary that has finally begun to speak in earnest: the only relic in the history of the form whose voice is not a

metaphor. Hahn's findings fit it closely. The silver arm contains no flesh; the Relic speaks of its function, re-embodiment, rather than of its contents; and the engram is a fragment that insists, with mounting urgency, on a larger whole, which is to say on a body.

4.4 The Accountancy of the Hereafter

Jacques Le Goff's *The Birth of Purgatory* (1981) dated to the late twelfth century the consolidation of a third place in the Christian afterlife, an intermediate state in which souls were purged over a measurable duration that the prayers, masses, and alms of the living could shorten. Purgatory introduced time, and therefore accounting, into the hereafter. Jacques Chiffoleau's study of late medieval Avignon testaments, *La Comptabilité de l'au-delà* (1980), documented the result, drawing on thousands of wills in a book prefaced by Le Goff himself: testaments that multiplied commissioned masses for the dead to the point of what Chiffoleau elsewhere called their obsessive use, a quantification of salvation he named the accountancy of the beyond. The indulgence trade was its logical culmination. Luther's twenty-seventh thesis (1517), answering a sales jingle that rhymed in German, condemned as merely human doctrine the preaching that the soul flies out of purgatory as soon as the money clinks into the chest; his fifty-second declared it vain to trust in indulgence letters even if the pope himself were to offer his soul as security. Arasaka's service name completes a pun Luther could not have intended: the soul is the security.

Mikoshi is a purgatory and Secure Your Soul an indulgence. The engrams in Arasaka's vault occupy an intermediate state, awaiting a resurrection that the corporation alone can grant—re-embodiment once a suitable body is found—and the price of admission is contractual. Walter Benjamin's fragment "Capitalism as Religion" (1921) described capitalism as a purely cultic religion, without dogma, of permanent duration, which does not expiate guilt but universalizes it, playing on the double sense of *Schuld* as guilt and debt. Arasaka's soteriology is Benjamin's religion in its final form: salvation as service, *Schuld* as subscription, the soul secured by a contract whose counterparty never dies. Such a contract presupposes that persons own the selves they sell, which is exactly what Kant denied when he held that a human being is his own master but not his own owner.

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954) described modern technology as an enframing (*Gestell*) that challenges everything forth as standing-reserve (*Bestand*), available on call for further ordering, and warned that the human being is in danger of becoming standing-reserve in turn, as the phrase "human resources" betrays. Mikoshi is the *Bestand* of souls: persons held on call for deployment into bodies.

Gilles Deleuze, in his "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990), remarked that we are now taught that corporations have a soul, which he called "the most

terrifying news in the world." In Night City the news is literal. The corporation does not merely have a soul; it owns souls, and Mikoshi is where it keeps them. Deleuze's *dividual*—the subject decomposed into samples, data, and passwords, governed by continuous modulation rather than enclosure—is the engram's political form, and Chapter Five follows that modulation from the vault into the living.

Accumulation by Exhumation

4.5

David Harvey's *The New Imperialism* (2003) named "accumulation by dispossession" the continuing primitive accumulation by which capital privatizes public assets, encloses commons, and financializes what had stood outside the market. *Accumulation by exhumation* names its posthumous extension: the conversion of the dead—their bodies, records, styles, names, and minds—into assets. Marx's most famous figure of capital becomes, in Night City, a surgical description: "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (*Capital* I, ch. 10). The dead engram consumes V's living neural tissue; the dead patriarch's engram is destined for his son's living body. The vampire has left the metaphor and entered the clinic.

The operation has an exact literary genealogy. In Dick's *Ubik* (1969), the Beloved Brethren Moratorium in Zürich keeps the dead in cold-pac, where relatives pay to converse with them while their "half-life" dwindles with each consultation, and a predatory half-lifer feeds on the others: the first fully commercial afterlife in science fiction. In *Blade Runner 2049* (2017), the plot begins with a box of bones exhumed beneath a dead tree. They belong to Rachael, they prove that a replicant has given birth, and the industrialist Niander Wallace wants the secret in order to scale replicant reproduction: capital exhumes a dead woman's remains to multiply its labor force. In Katsuhiro Otomo's *Akira* (manga 1982–90; film 1988), the remains of the boy-god are kept in cryogenic containers beneath the site of the Olympic stadium, objects of state secrecy and, in the manga, of a messianic cult. Each is accumulation by exhumation, and *2077* gathers them into a single economy.

Kronos in the Boardroom

4.6

Saburo Arasaka, kept alive by medicine for more than a century and a half, is murdered by his son Yorinobu at Konpeki Plaza. Hesiod's *Theogony* (453–506) tells of Kronos swallowing his children to forestall his overthrow, and of Zeus's escape and revolt; Goya painted Saturn devouring his son on a wall of his house around 1819–23. In the ending V reaches through Hanako Arasaka, Saburo's engram appears before the board to expose his son, and the plan is carried through: Hanako uploads her father's engram into Yorinobu's mind, erasing the son so that the father may resume command. Kronos does not devour the son; he moves into him. The son's revolt is

annulled not by punishment but by possession. Freud's dead father here acquires a medical procedure.

The privilege of posthumous presence has always been a class privilege. Polybius described the Roman aristocratic funeral, in which actors wore the wax *imagines* of the family's distinguished ancestors and rode before the bier in their insignia of office, so that the dead magistrates seemed to return in procession (6.53–54); the right to display such images, the *ius imaginum*, belonged to families whose members had held high office. Secure Your Soul is a corporate *ius imaginum*: the right to persist after death, allocated by wealth. Folklore supplies the fantasy that underwrites it. James George Frazer collected in *The Golden Bough* (1890) the motif of the external soul, of which the Russian Koschei the Deathless is the classic instance: his death is hidden in a needle, inside an egg, inside a duck, inside a hare, inside a chest buried beneath an oak on a distant island. Mikoshi is Koschei's chest.

The literary tradition has long doubted the desirability of such persistence. Swift's Struldbrugs (*Gulliver's Travels*, 1726, III.10) are immortals who age without end and are declared legally dead at eighty. Karel Čapek's *The Makropulos Affair* (1922) presents a singer of 337 years so exhausted by duration that she finally refuses the elixir, and Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case" (1973) argued that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that make life worth continuing. Saburo is a Makropulos who never tired, and the reason is instructive. The categorical desire that sustains him is not his own but capital's: the endless self-valorization of value is the one desire that never exhausts itself, and the patriarch who embodies it borrows its immortality.

4.7 Mikoshi: The Palanquin of the God

A *mikoshi* is the portable shrine in which a *kami* is carried through the streets during a festival. Arasaka names its engram vault after the vehicle of a god, so that the stored dead become *kami* in transit, ancestors elevated to divinity under corporate ownership. The *Kojiki* (712) supplies the Japanese archetype of descent to the dead: Izanagi follows his dead wife Izanami into Yomi, breaks her prohibition by looking upon her decaying body, flees, and seals the pass of Yomotsu Hirasaka with a boulder, across which the estranged couple exchange a curse and a counter-pledge—a thousand deaths a day against fifteen hundred births. As a paronomastic resonance rather than an etymological claim, the corporate name written 荒坂, the "wild slope," echoes the *-saka* of the slope that divides the living from the dead. Julian Jaynes's *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind* (1976) described ancient "god-houses" in which the statues of dead kings were fed, clothed, and consulted, their voices still heard; Mikoshi is a god-house in which the dead kings still speak.

The Japanese vocabulary demands critical scrutiny. David Morley and Kevin Robins named "techno-Orientalism" (1995) the Western figuration of Japan, during

the trade panic of the 1980s, as a future without humanity: technologically supreme and spiritually void. Arasaka was born in 1988 from that anxiety, and *2077* inherits it, even as it gives the Arasaka family a contested interior through Yorinobu's rebellion, Hanako's filial piety, and Goro Takemura's loyalty. The use of Shinto vocabulary as the dress of corporate necromancy risks reproducing the trope that couples Asian modernity with ancestral death-cults (Roh, Huang, and Niu 2015). A reading attentive to necromantic capital must therefore insist that Mikoshi's logic is capitalist rather than Japanese. Dick's moratorium stands in Zürich; the tiered digital afterlife of the series *Upload* (2020) is run from California; the Relic is merely the most elegant instrument of a regime whose address is global.

CHAPTER FIVE

05

> *The metaphysics of the copy asks whether it is really him. The politics of reactivation asks by what right, and for whose benefit, he returns.*

Engrammatic Personhood

Trace, Copy, and the Politics of Reactivation

Semon's Engram and the Politics of Ecphory

5.1

THE GERMAN ZOOLOGIST Richard Semon introduced the term *engram* in *Die Mneme* (1904) for the enduring change that a stimulus leaves in living substance, the trace by which an organism retains its past. He called the process of inscription *engraphy* and the reactivation of the trace, by a partial return of the original conditions, *ecphory*. Semon's vocabulary had a long and uneven afterlife. Karl Lashley's "In Search of the Engram" (1950) concluded, after decades of cortical lesion experiments, that the trace could not be localized, and the term returned to the center of neuroscience only in the twenty-first century, when Susumu Tonegawa's laboratory reported the optogenetic reactivation of hippocampal "engram cells" that elicited fear recall in

mice (Liu et al. 2012) and the implantation of a false memory (Ramirez et al. 2013). In their review of the field, Sheena Josselyn and Tonegawa (2020) treat the engram as an object that can be tagged, silenced, and artificially recalled. Ecphory has become an engineering problem.

Night City is organized around engineered ecphory. Soulkiller extracts an engram while destroying the brain that held it; Mikoshi stores engrams; the Relic re-engraphs an engram into a living host; the braindance records and replays experience. Each technology answers the same question differently: who commands the ecphory? Who decides which traces of the dead return, into which bodies, under whose title, and to whose profit? The formula that organizes this chapter parodies Schmitt's definition of sovereignty: *sovereign is he who decides on the ecphory*. Ecphoric sovereignty is the power to authorize the return of the dead.

5.2 Pharmakon, Retention, Archive

The philosophical prehistory of the engram begins with writing. In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), the god Theuth presents writing to King Thamus as a drug (*pharmakon*) for memory; Thamus replies that it is a drug for reminding (*hypomnesis*) rather than remembering (*mneme*), and that it will produce forgetfulness in the souls of those who learn it. Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) showed that the *pharmakon* is undecidably remedy and poison, and that writing is the supplement philosophy both requires and disavows. Husserl's lectures on the consciousness of internal time distinguished primary retention, the just-past held within the living present, from secondary retention, the recollected past. Bernard Stiegler added a third term in *Technics and Time* (1994–2001): *tertiary retention*, the technical exteriorization of memory in writing, phonography, and cinema, which conditions the other two. Industrial "temporal objects," such as films and broadcasts, synchronize the retentions of millions of consciousnesses and so enable what Stiegler called the hyper-industrial capture of attention. André Leroi-Gourhan's *Gesture and Speech* (1964–65) had already made the exteriorization of memory the axis of hominization.

The engram is the terminal tertiary retention: not a record of experience but a record of the experiencer. Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) recalled that the Greek *arkheion* was the house of the archons, the magistrates who held both the documents and the right to interpret them; there is no political power without control of the archive, and the archive is haunted by the death drive, since it preserves only by replacing the living memory it records. Soulkiller makes Derrida's paradox literal. To archive a person, it kills them. The archive drive and the death drive coincide in a single operation; Mikoshi is the *arkheion*, and Arasaka is its archon.

The Classical Problem

5.3

V's condition reactivates the canonical cases of the philosophy of personal identity within a single body. Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694, II.xxvii), located personal identity in consciousness extended backward through memory, and offered the case of the prince and the cobbler (§15): should the soul of a prince, carrying the consciousness of the prince's past life, enter the body of a cobbler, the resulting man would be the same person as the prince. Locke also called "person" a "forensic term," one that appropriates actions and their merit (§26). Thomas Reid's paradox of the brave officer (1785) and Joseph Butler's objection that memory presupposes identity rather than constituting it (1736) exposed the limits of the memory criterion. Hume, entering most intimately into what he called himself, never caught himself without a perception, and concluded that the self is a bundle (*Treatise* 1.4.6). Descartes imagined an evil genius capable of deceiving him about everything except the fact that he was thinking (Meditations I–II), and Lichtenberg proposed that one should say "it thinks," as one says "it lightens," a correction Nietzsche endorsed (*Beyond Good and Evil* §17).

The Relic stages all of these at once. Johnny's consciousness migrating into V's body is Locke's prince entering the cobbler in slow motion. The Relic's capacity to produce hallucinations and to seize motor control installs a Cartesian demon inside the skull. The thoughts that arise in V's head are of increasingly undecidable ownership, so that Lichtenberg's "it thinks" becomes a clinical report. Above all, Locke's forensic person returns as the operative concept. When V cedes the body to Johnny for a night in the Silverhand questline, the question raised is not metaphysical but juridical: to whom are the acts of that night imputable, and who answers for them?

Parfit's Liberation and Its Limits

5.4

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) is the most sustained philosophical anticipation of V's predicament. Its teletransportation cases include the Branch-Line Case, in which the scanner that sends a replica to Mars damages the original's heart, so that the original, still on Earth, will die within days while the replica lives on. Parfit argued that the original's prospect is nearly as good as ordinary survival, because what matters is Relation R—psychological connectedness and continuity—rather than identity. He added that this conclusion freed him: his life had seemed a glass tunnel, and when he changed his view its walls disappeared, and he cared less about his own death.

V's diagnosis is a malign Branch-Line Case. The body continues, but its psychological continuant is increasingly another person, Johnny, rather than a replica of V. Parfitian consolation therefore fails, since what survives is R-related to someone else. Yet the ending called *Temperance* can be read as a Parfitian act: a V released

from the glass tunnel of identity gives the body to another. Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) had shown that the same scenario, described once as a body exchange and once as memory erasure followed by torture, elicits opposed intuitions about who survives. The game exploits both descriptions, since Johnny's takeover can be narrated as an exchange of bodies or as the destruction of V within a continuing body. Robert Nozick's closest continuer theory (1981) adds that identity depends on whether a later entity is one's closest continuer and close enough. The closest psychological continuer of V's body is shifting, week by week, from V to Johnny. Plutarch's ship of Theseus, whose planks the Athenians replaced as they decayed (*Theseus* 23), and Hobbes's addition, which asks which vessel would be the ship if the discarded planks were reassembled (*De Corpore* II.11.7), describe the process exactly. V's neural tissue is rebuilt plank by plank to another ship's plans, while the original ship, Johnny's body, has long since been burned.

5.5 Hylomorphism and the Separated Soul

In the *Theaetetus* (191c–d), Socrates proposes that each soul contains a block of wax, the gift of Mnemosyne, mother of the Muses, into which perceptions and thoughts are stamped as with a signet ring. Semon's *engram*, from *en-graphein*, "to inscribe," inherits the image. Aristotle's *De Anima* defines the soul as the first actuality of a natural body that potentially has life, and adds that one need no more ask whether soul and body are one than whether the wax and its impression are one (II.1, 412a–b). For Aristotle the impression is the form of *this* wax; it cannot be lifted and pressed into other wax without becoming another impression. The Relic is an anti-Aristotelian device. It claims to lift a form from one matter and press it into another, and the game's horror lies in showing what that operation does to the wax that receives it.

Christian theology preserved the Aristotelian intuition in its doctrine of the separated soul. Commenting on the fifteenth chapter of First Corinthians, Thomas Aquinas wrote *anima mea non est ego*: my soul is not I. The separated soul awaits the resurrection of its own body, and only that reunion restores the person. Mikoshi is a Thomist purgatory without Thomist metaphysics. Its engrams are separated souls awaiting bodies, but other bodies, in defiance of the doctrine that the resurrected body is numerically one's own. Arasaka's soteriology is a heresy of the resurrection.

5.6 Literary Engrams

The literature of the copied mind places the problem at different nodes, and the comparison clarifies what the Relic adds. Gibson's Dixie Flatline (1984) is a construct that asks to be erased; the novel's coda, which glimpses him persisting within the matrix, leaves it uncertain whether the request was honored. Effinger's "moddies"

(1987) temporarily overwrite a wearer with another personality, and Rudy Rucker's *Software* (1982) transfers its aging protagonist's mind into a robot body. Greg Egan's "Learning to Be Me" (1990) is the closest analogue to the Relic: a neural "jewel" implanted in infancy learns to mimic the brain until the brain can be discarded, and the narrator discovers that his jewel has diverged, so that the switch will replace him with a stranger. Richard K. Morgan's *Altered Carbon* (2002) stratifies immortality by class, granting the wealthy remote backups of their minds, while Catholics, whose religious coding forbids revival in a new body, can be murdered without being resurrected to testify: a refusal of reactivation turned into a vulnerability. Mamoru Oshii's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995) imagines that copying a mind degrades the original, and gives its artificial intelligence a desire to merge with a human being in order to acquire variation and mortality. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) returns to the psychologist Kelvin his dead wife, assembled from his own memories: a revenant built out of another's engrams. *Black Mirror* reconstructs a dead partner from his online traces in "Be Right Back" (2013) and enslaves digital copies of consciousness as domestic assistants in "White Christmas" (2014). Identity, class, grief, labor, and reproduction are each assigned a narrative laboratory; *Cyberpunk 2077* fuses them in a single body.

From the Metaphysics of the Copy to the Politics of Reactivation

5.7

The game declines to settle whether its Johnny is the Johnny of 2023. It marks his engram as altered by capture, storage, and cohabitation, and it leaves the question of authenticity open. Its interest lies elsewhere: in who may reactivate whom. Locke's forensic person thus becomes the decisive category, and personhood appears as a juridical allocation of acts, merit, and property rather than as a metaphysical fact. Night City distributes ecphoric sovereignty hierarchically. Arasaka decides which dead return and into whom; NetWatch decides what may cross the Blackwall; the Voodoo Boys seek the ecphory of Alt Cunningham; the braindance industry sells the ecphory of experience; and V, at the end, decides the ecphory of Johnny. The endgame is therefore a referendum on ecphoric sovereignty. The metaphysics of the copy asks whether it is really him. The politics of reactivation asks by what right, and for whose benefit, he returns.

Ecphoric sovereignty is not confined to the dead. In the side job "Dream On," V discovers that the penthouse of the mayoral candidate Jefferson Peralez and his wife has been turned into an instrument: watchers concealed behind its smart glass monitor the couple, control their diet, and tamper with Jefferson's brain, altering his convictions while he continues to experience them as his own. Deleuze's society of control names the operation: not the confinement of a subject but the continuous modulation of its dispositions. A living politician becomes an engram edited in

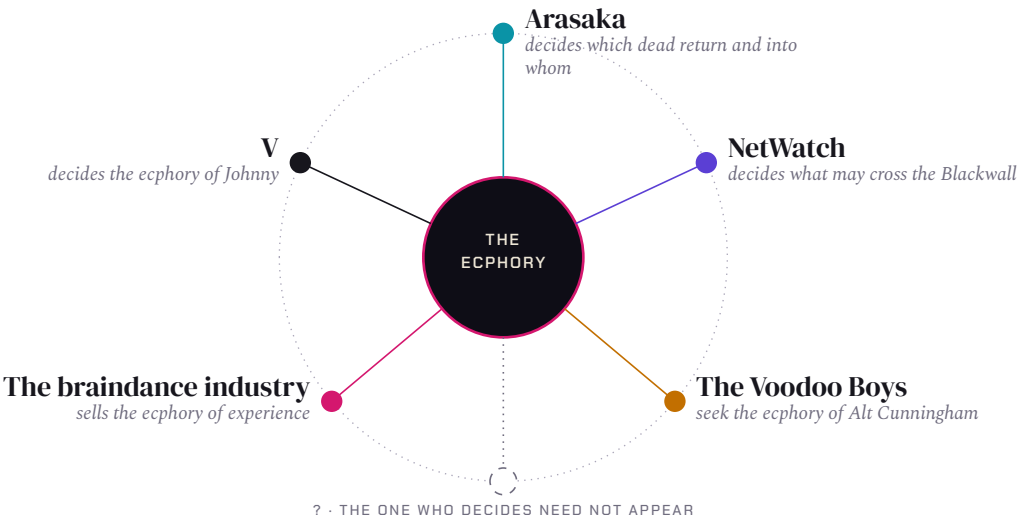


FIG. 05 **Who commands the ecphory?.** *Night City distributes ecphoric sovereignty hierarchically; in "Dream On," the one who decides what returns, and in what form, need not appear.*

place. V must then decide whether to tell him, and so holds, in miniature, the power this chapter has described: the decision whether a man will know that his mind has been rewritten. The quest's refusal to identify the agency, which its designers have confirmed is deliberate, is itself an argument: under ecphoric sovereignty, the one who decides what returns, and in what form, need not appear.

CHAPTER SIX

06

Johnny is that corpse, and he speaks.

Bispectrality

Johnny Silverhand and the Inheritance of Revolt

Specters

6.1

JACQUES DERRIDA'S *Specters of Marx* (1993) named *hauntology* the logic of what is neither present nor absent, neither living nor dead, and opened with Hamlet's sentence that the time is out of joint. Among the specter's attributes Derrida singled out the "visor effect": the ghost of Hamlet's father appears armored, and it sees without being seen. Johnny Silverhand's mirrored aviator lenses are the visor effect in costume; the dead man looks at the living from behind a surface that returns only their own reflection. For Derrida, inheritance is never a given but always a task: one inherits only by filtering, selecting, and reaffirming. Mark Fisher's *Ghosts of My Life* (2014) gave hauntology a cultural diagnosis—the persistence of lost futures in

a present that can no longer imagine new ones—and borrowed from Franco "Bifo" Berardi the phrase "the slow cancellation of the future" (2011).

Cyberpunk 2077 is a hauntological artifact in Fisher's sense: a future imagined in the 1980s, delivered in 2020, and spoken in the language of the twentieth century. Its quests are named after earlier songs—"Pyramid Song," "Sinnerman," "Riders on the Storm," "Life During Wartime," "Dream On," "Epistrophy," "(Don't Fear) The Reaper"—so that the future can name itself only in a borrowed tongue. Marx had diagnosed precisely this in *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852): the tradition of all dead generations weighs like a nightmare on the brains of the living, and in moments of revolutionary crisis men conjure the spirits of the past, borrowing their names, battle slogans, and costumes. V's brain literally carries a dead generation, and V's final assault on Arasaka Tower re-enacts Johnny's assault of 2023. Marx added that history repeats itself first as tragedy and then as farce. The endings ask whether a third possibility exists: a mourning that converts repetition into difference. Raoul Vaneigem warned in *The Revolution of Everyday Life* (1967) that those who speak of revolution without reference to everyday life have "a corpse in their mouth." Johnny is that corpse, and he speaks.

6.2 The Oracular Head

The deepest mythic template for Johnny Silverhand is Orphic. In Virgil's fourth *Georgic* and Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (X–XI), the singer Orpheus descends to the underworld for Eurydice, wins her release by song, and loses her by looking back; he is later torn apart by Ciconian women, and his severed head floats down the Hebrus with his lyre, still lamenting, until it reaches Lesbos. Philostratus records the tradition that the head gave oracles there (*Life of Apollonius* 4.14). In the tabletop lore, Johnny, a musician, attempted in 2013 to rescue Alt Cunningham from Arasaka's custody: a descent into the corporate underworld for a beloved who could not be retrieved, since she had already been soulkilled. In 2023 he led the assault on Arasaka Tower, was captured, and was soulkilled in turn. His engram survived in storage as a severed singing head, and, reactivated within V's skull, it prophesies: it foretells V's death and testifies to the crimes of the corporation that killed him.

The Japanese archetype converges with the Greek. Izanagi's descent into Yomi, his forbidden look at his dead wife, his flight, and the boulder he sets at the pass between the worlds (*Kojiki*) form a second Orphic plot, and the game stages its reversal. In Mikoshi, Johnny meets Alt again, and she is no longer the woman he lost. Eurydice has become a power of the underworld, closer to Persephone—a queen who negotiates the terms of return rather than a shade awaiting rescue. The Orphic doctrine that Plato attributes to "those around Orpheus," that the body (*soma*) is the tomb and sign (*sema*) of the soul (*Cratylus* 400c; compare *Gorgias* 493a), completes the picture: V's body is the sign and tomb of Johnny's soul as well as of V's own. Dante

supplies a final figure in Bertran de Born, the troubadour who set a son against his father and who walks through the eighth circle carrying his severed head like a lantern, a punishment Dante names *contrapasso* (*Inferno* 28.118–142). The rock poet as instigator of filial revolt, the speaking severed head, and the lantern carried into the underworld all return when Johnny guides V into Mikoshi.

Daimon, Bicameral God, Shadow, Double

6.3

Socrates told his judges that since childhood he had been accompanied by a divine sign, a voice that only ever turned him away from what he was about to do and never urged him forward (*Apology* 31c–d). Johnny is an inverted *daimonion*: a voice of negation that dissuades V from every compromise with Arasaka and the system and urges insurrection instead of restraint. Julian Jaynes (1976) argued that early humans obeyed hallucinated voices experienced as gods, often the remembered voices of dead kings, and that consciousness emerged from the breakdown of this bicameral arrangement. The Relic re-bicameralizes V. The authoritative voice of a dead king —here the king of a counterculture—speaks within a mind that had believed itself sovereign.

Carl Jung's concept of the Shadow (*Aion*, 1951) names the repressed aspects of a personality that must be integrated rather than denied or obeyed. Johnny is V's Shadow, carrying aggression, contempt, charisma, and self-destructiveness, and the game's relational arc tests whether integration is possible without possession. Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) argued that the double originates as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death, and later becomes the uncanny harbinger of death; Freud adopted Rank's formulation in "The Uncanny" (1919). The Relic is Rank's dialectic in one device: it resurrected V, and it is killing V. Freud's *unheimlich*, the familiar made strange, describes V's condition literally. V is not at home in their own head, and the mirror scenes in which V's reflection yields to Johnny's are the genre's most exact image of the uncanny.

The Crypt and the Phantom

6.4

In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917), Freud distinguished mourning, in which libido is gradually withdrawn from the lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated through identification, so that, in his phrase, the shadow of the object falls upon the ego. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok refined the distinction. *Introjection* is the gradual assimilation of loss, which enlarges the ego; *incorporation* is a fantasy that swallows the lost object whole, refuses mourning, and installs the object in an intrapsychic *crypt*, where it lives on as a living dead. Their essay on the *phantom* (1975) described the unspeakable secret of another, transmitted across generations, lodged in a subject's unconscious and speaking through it.

Derrida's preface to their work, "Fors" (1976), read the crypt as a sealed interior that the self cannot enter.

The Relic is the crypt made material: a sealed and encrypted vault within the skull in which a dead man lives on. Cryptography and cryptophoria converge. Johnny carries an unspeakable secret—the truth of his death and of what was done to him after 2023—and it speaks through V. The questline that tracks their relationship is titled "Tapeworm," naming the occupant as a parasite; Hobbes's worms in the entrails of a natural man return at the scale of a single skull. The work of the questline is the conversion of incorporation into introjection, of a parasite into an interlocutor. Whether that conversion succeeds, and at what cost, is what the endings decide.

6.5 The Doomed Man

Sergei Nechayev's *Catechism of a Revolutionary* (1869) opens by declaring the revolutionary a doomed man, without personal interests, attachments, property, or name, who has severed every tie with the civil order and lives for destruction alone. This is the posthumous subject before the letter: one who lives as already dead to society. Bakunin had written in 1842 that the passion for destruction is a creative passion, and Dostoevsky's *Demons* (1871–72) dissected the Nechayevist cell. Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) drew the decisive distinction. Rebellion begins with a "no" that implies a "yes," the affirmation of a limit and of a shared human nature, summarized in the formula "I rebel—therefore we exist." Revolution betrays rebellion when it legitimizes murder, and Camus answered it with an ethic of measure.

Johnny's career is a parable of Camus's distinction. The rebellion of the musician curdles into the terror of 2023: a nuclear detonation in the center of a city, during the raid he led, with mass civilian casualties. The game's relationship system permits a moral education under V's influence, a slow return from revolution to rebellion, from the absolute to the limit, legible in Johnny's willingness at the threshold of Mikoshi to let V live rather than reclaim the body for his war. Milton's Satan, who judged it better to reign in Hell than to serve in Heaven (*Paradise Lost* 1.263), and whom Blake and Shelley read as the poem's true hero, supplies the Romantic matrix of Johnny's charisma. Its danger is that the Romantic rebel's revolt can itself become necromantic. Johnny at first wants V's body to continue his war, and the tradition of revolt becomes one more dead generation weighing on a living brain.

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) explains the appeal of the act without excusing it. For Bataille, every society produces a surplus that must be spent without return—in sacrifice, festival, luxury, or war—and sovereignty belongs to the moment of useless expenditure that refuses subordination to any future gain. Johnny's most famous summons to V ends with the declaration that "we have a city to burn," and the bombing of 2023 is sovereign expenditure in Bataille's exact sense: the destruction of accumulated value without return, the absolute negation of

an economy of storage. It is therefore the purest antithesis of necromantic capital, which spends nothing and keeps everything, the dead included. That is precisely why this dissertation must judge it rather than admire it. The expenditure was paid for with the lives of people who had no part in the war between Johnny and Arasaka, and Camus's distinction applies without remainder: a revolt that legitimizes mass murder has ceased to be rebellion. Necromantic capital and Johnny's counter-violence are opposed as hoarding is to squandering, but both dispose of human lives as material—the one by keeping them, the other by burning them.

The Rebel Sell and the Paratextual Paradox

6.6

Hebdige showed how subcultures are neutralized through incorporation; Thomas Frank's *The Conquest of Cool* (1997) documented how the advertising industry of the 1960s adopted the counterculture's critique of conformity as its own idiom; Joseph Heath and Andrew Potter's *The Rebel Sell* (2004) argued that countercultural rebellion has become a driver of consumption. Inside Night City, Johnny's revolt is already a brand. His image sells, his band's songs circulate on the radio, and Kerry Eurodyne's questline stages a reunion of Samurai around a dead frontman. The band chosen to perform Samurai's music, Refused, had disbanded in 1998 with a farewell statement proclaiming its own death and re-formed in 2012: a band that had already lived the posthumous reunion it was hired to stage. Its 1998 album, *The Shape of Punk to Come*, borrowed its title from Ornette Coleman's *The Shape of Jazz to Come* (1959), announcing a future in a borrowed name.

The casting of Keanu Reeves compounds the effect. The actor of *Johnny Mnemonic* and *The Matrix* has, in the *John Wick* cycle (2014–), built a late persona organized around mourning. The paratextual paradox is plain: a global marketing campaign deployed an anti-corporate avatar to sell a corporate commodity produced under widely reported crunch. Linda Hutcheon's concept of "complicitous critique" (1989) names the postmodern parody that inscribes what it contests. The game is not innocent of its paradox—its script lets Johnny register his own commodification with contempt—but recognizing a paradox does not dissolve it.

Two Ghosts, One Body

6.7

V receives two ghostly commands. Hanako Arasaka asks V to help restore her dead father's will; Johnny asks V to burn the tower of the corporation that killed him. Hamlet's father demands remembrance and revenge, and Derrida opens *Specters of Marx* with Hamlet because the play stages inheritance as a demand issued by the dead. *Bispectrality* names V's condition: a living body as the site of a dispute between two specters—the specter of capital and the specter of revolt—each of which claims it as an estate. V's freedom lies in the selective and critical inheritance Derrida

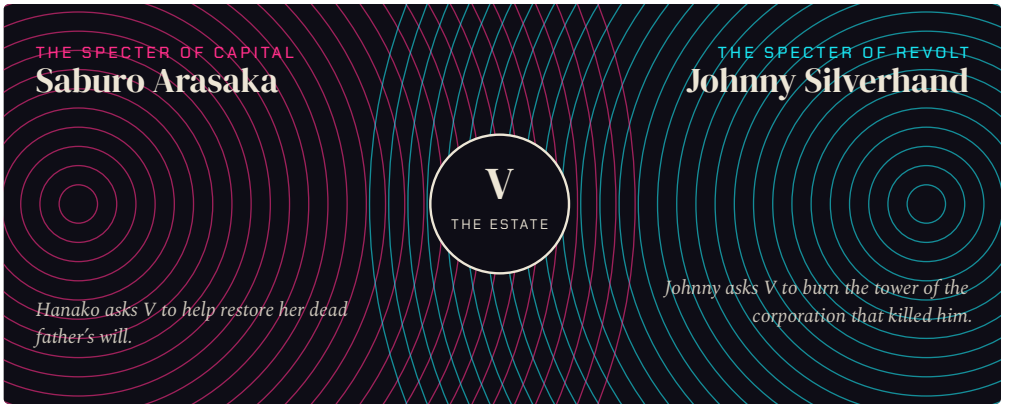


FIG. 06 **Bispectrality.** *A living body as the site of a dispute between two specters, each of which claims it as an estate.*

describes, the task of choosing what to reaffirm from what one has been given. The endings are therefore not merely outcomes but modes of inheritance, and Chapter Ten reads them as such.

CHAPTER SEVEN

07

The braindance is Mercerism with a revenue model.

The Braindance

Experience as Commodity, Death as Content

The Apparatus

7.1

THE BRAINDANCE RECORDS the full sensorium of a subject—sight, sound, touch, proprioception, and affect—through neural implants, and replays it through a headset that substitutes the recording for the wearer's own perception. In Night City it is the dominant entertainment medium, with recreational, pornographic, and educational genres alongside an illicit market in "XBDs," recordings of real violence, sexual violence, and death. The game makes braindance analysis a mechanic. V first learns the medium under the guidance of the editor Judy Alvarez, analyzing a recording in preparation for the Konpeki heist, and later uses it as an investigative instrument, scanning visual, audio, and thermal layers for what the original experi-

encer failed to notice. The braindance is thus at once an epistemic, an erotic, and a forensic medium. Its editors, of whom Judy is the game's exemplar, form a new class of artisan whose raw material is other people's experience.

7.2 Philosophical Genealogy

Robert Nozick's "experience machine" (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974) asked whether one would plug into a device that supplied any desired experience for life; Nozick expected refusal, on the grounds that we want to do things and not merely to have the experience of doing them, to be a certain kind of person, and to remain in contact with reality. Night City's braindance addicts are the population that answered yes. Thomas Nagel's "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" (1974) argued that the subjective character of experience is inaccessible from an external standpoint; the braindance sells precisely that interior. Frank Jackson's Mary (1982), who knows every physical fact about color yet learns something new on first seeing red, would find in the braindance the teacher she lacked. Thomas Metzinger's account of the phenomenal self-model (*Being No One*, 2003; *The Ego Tunnel*, 2009) describes the self as a transparent model the brain constructs; the braindance exchanges self-models, letting the wearer inhabit another's ego tunnel.

Two literary precedents complete the genealogy. Stanisław Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) coined "phantomatics" for the technology of producing artificial realities indistinguishable, for the subject, from the real—a term whose root already names a ghost. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* imagined the empathy box, through which the adherents of Mercerism fuse with the old man Wilbur Mercer as he climbs an endless slope under a hail of stones. Mercer is unmasked on television as an actor on a sound stage, and yet the fusion persists. The braindance is Mercerism with a revenue model.

7.3 Media Necrology

The history of recording media is a history of embalming. André Bazin's "The Ontology of the Photographic Image" (1945) proposed that a psychoanalysis of the plastic arts would find the embalming of the dead at their origin—a "mummy complex," the wish to preserve being from time—and described cinema as change mummified. Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980) located the photograph's essence in its "that-has-been" and described it as the return of the dead, in an argument organized around an unreproduced photograph of his dead mother. Susan Sontag called all photographs *memento mori* (*On Photography*, 1977) and later examined the spectatorship of others' suffering (*Regarding the Pain of Others*, 2003). Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) argued that the realm of the dead extends exactly as far as a culture's capacities for storage and transmission, and recalled that the

phonograph was early promoted as a means of preserving the voices of the dying. Jeffrey Sconce's *Haunted Media* (2000) and John Durham Peters's *Speaking into the Air* (1999) traced the spiritualist imagination that has accompanied every electronic medium since the telegraph.

Cinema had already imagined the braindance's necromantic horizon. In Douglas Trumbull's *Brainstorm* (1983), a scientist records the experience of her own death, and the recording becomes a forbidden object that the state seeks to control. In Kathryn Bigelow's *Strange Days* (1995), the SQUID device records full sensorium for black-market "playback," and the film's central atrocity is a clip that forces a victim to experience her own murder through the killer's senses. The braindance completes the series. It no longer preserves the image of the dead; it preserves the experience of dying, and it sells it. Heidegger held that no one can take another's dying away from them (*Being and Time* §47). The XBD market sells that dying as content: the ownmost becomes the most shareable.

Pharmacopornography

7.4

Paul B. Preciado's *Testo Junkie* (2008) described the post-Fordist economy as *pharmacopornographic*: a regime in which subjectivity is produced through biomolecular technologies such as pharmaceuticals and hormones and through semiotic-technical ones such as pornography, and whose raw material is the body's capacity for excitation, which Preciado calls *potentia gaudendi*. The braindance industry is pharmacopornographic in the strictest sense. It sells a neural product that addicts like a drug, and its leading genres are sex and violence.

Clouds, a luxury brothel in Japantown known as a "dollhouse," extends the regime into sexual labor. Its sex workers, called dolls, run behavioral chips that suppress their own consciousness while clients have sex with them, and a profile of each client's desires configures the persona the client meets. The worker's consent is given in advance, by contract, to acts at which she will not be present. The doll chip is therefore the limit case of the labor contract: a person consents to her own absence, and the question whether consent given beforehand can stand in for consent at the moment of the act—the central question of sexual ethics—is answered by a device that removes the one who could answer it. Arlie Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983) defined emotional labor as the management of feeling to produce a publicly observable display, and documented the estrangement it exacts; Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri (2000) generalized the category as affective labor. The doll chip completes emotional labor by removing the laborer from her labor, a solution the television series *Severance* (2022) would later imagine as surgically divided memory. The literary prehistory is older still. In Villiers de l'Isle-Adam's *L'Ève future* (1886), a fictional Edison builds Hadaly, an artificial woman whose speech issues from phonographic recordings and who is finally animated by the spirit of a sleeping

woman: the first android of modern literature is a recording inhabited by a borrowed soul. E. T. A. Hoffmann's automaton Olympia in "The Sandman" (1816), the tale from which Freud drew much of "The Uncanny," stands at the head of the same line.

Evelyn Parker, the doll who planned the Konpeki heist as a means of authoring her own exit, is the game's indictment of this regime, and her fate can be stated precisely. While she works at Clouds, a virus attacks her during a session with a client and leaves her comatose: the chip that removes the worker from her labor has left her defenseless. Woodman, the dollhouse's manager, takes her to the ripperdoc Fingers on Jig-Jig Street, ostensibly to repair her malfunctioning cyberware; Fingers sells her to scavengers through the fixer Wakako Okada; and the scavengers are the trade that harvests bodies and produces snuff braindances. When V and Judy Alvarez rescue her in the quest "Disasterpiece," she is still comatose and wired by cable to the scavengers' equipment. She survives the rescue but not what was done to her: she later dies by suicide. Her trajectory demonstrates the continuity of the doll economy and the XBD economy—first the suppression of a person during her labor, then her sale as raw material for recorded suffering. Each actor in the chain is a broker: Woodman manages, Fingers sells, Wakako brokers, the scavengers produce, and none of them needs to believe themselves responsible for the whole. Wakako is the detail that implicates the player, since she is one of the fixers who give V work; the platform economy through which V earns a living is the economy that sold Evelyn. Her death becomes the hinge of Judy's questline, in which grief turns toward the question of who controls Clouds: the doll economy answered, however incompletely, by an attempt to change who owns it.

7.5 The Passion as Product: "Sinnerman"

The side quest "Sinnerman" follows Joshua Stephenson, a condemned murderer turned penitent, who consents to be crucified in a braindance produced by Rachel Casich, with a preacher at his side. V accompanies him toward the cross. Mercerism's commercial potential is here fully realized: the passion that founded Christian time is restaged as content with a production schedule. Guy Debord's *The Society of the Spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle as a social relation among people mediated by images, and Stiegler's industrial temporal object describes the synchronization of many consciousnesses to a single recorded flow. The braindance of a crucifixion combines both: an audience invited not to watch a death but to undergo it.

Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technical reproducibility (1935–36) argued that reproduction withers the aura, the unique here-and-now of the work. The braindance restores a counterfeit aura: the here-and-now of a unique death, reproduced without limit. Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) adds that death is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, since a life first assumes trans-

missible form at the moment of dying. The braindance industrializes that sanction. The quest declines to resolve its own ambiguity. V may support or undermine the production, and Joshua's sincerity is never mocked. What stands indicted is the apparatus that converts a sincere death into inventory.

Counter-Uses: The Forensic Dance

7.6

The braindance is also a pharmakon in Derrida's sense. In River Ward's questline, analysis of a killer's recordings leads V to a kidnapped boy from River's family; the editor's layers disclose what the experiencer did not register. Benjamin's "optical unconscious," the dimension of reality that only the camera can reveal, is extended here to the thermal and acoustic unconscious of an experience. Judy Alvarez's craft points toward a counter-practice of the medium—editing as care, analysis as testimony—that the industry's economics continually overwhelm. The braindance is not intrinsically necromantic. It becomes necromantic when the experience of the dying is extracted without consent, stored for resale, and consumed as spectacle. The same apparatus that makes death content can make it evidence, and Chapter Eleven returns to this ambivalence as a general feature of the street's relation to its dead.

Testimony and the Drowned

7.7

The forensic use of the braindance raises a question the industry suppresses: whether a recording of dying can bear witness. Primo Levi, who survived Auschwitz, wrote in *The Drowned and the Saved* (1986) that the survivors are not the true witnesses. The true witnesses, in his account, are those who went to the bottom: the murdered, and the prisoners whom starvation and exhaustion had brought to the threshold of death, whom camp slang called *Muselmänner*. Giorgio Agamben's *Remnants of Auschwitz* (1998) made Levi's paradox the core of a theory of testimony: the complete witness is the one who cannot testify, and testimony is always spoken by a survivor on behalf of a silence. The comparison drawn here concerns the structure of testimony; it does not equate a fictional entertainment medium with the Nazi German genocide of Europe's Jews and its other victims.

Within that limit, the braindance is cyberpunk's fantasy of abolishing Levi's lacuna: a technology that would record the experience of the one who goes to the bottom. Night City shows what the fantasy produces under necromantic capital. The XBD is not the victim's testimony but the perpetrator's archive. It is recorded by those who inflict the harm, owned by those who sell it, and consumed by those who pay to occupy the victim's place. It does not speak for the dead; it sells their silence back as sensation. The forensic dance in River Ward's questline is the counter-case, in which a killer's own recordings are turned against him on behalf of a living

child. The difference between the two uses is the difference between testimony and content.

7.8 The Modular Body and the Billboard

The pharmacopornographic regime governs the player's own avatar as well. The character creator treats body type, voice, and genitals as independently selectable components, so that the body is assembled as a modular kit, and the design literalizes Judith Butler's account of gender as sedimented performance and Preciado's account of gender as a technically produced program. The same system re-binds some of what it opens. Romance is gated by body type and voice, and the gating is asymmetrical: the two same-gender romances, with Judy Alvarez and Kerry Eurodyne, require both body type and voice to match, while the two opposite-gender romances, with Panam Palmer and River Ward, require only body type; genitals play no part at all. Desire is keyed to the coherence of a configured gender rather than to anatomy, and queer desire is asked for more coherence than straight desire. Within the fiction, Claire Russell, a trans woman and former Militech engineer who tends bar at the Afterlife, has installed no cyberware at all, and it is she who names the bar's drinks after the city's legends. In a city where bodies are rebuilt from catalogs, the character who keeps her body unaugmented is the curator of its posthumous names; Chapter Eleven returns to her as the keeper of the Bar.

The game's advertising imagery drew the sharpest criticism. A billboard for the Chromanticore brand, captioned "Mix It Up," presents a transgender model in a sexualized pose. Critics, many of them trans players and writers, argued that the image reproduced the objectification of trans bodies it purported to satirize; defenders read it as a critique of corporate commodification. Hutcheon's concept of complicitous critique names the structure without settling the dispute. A satire of the commodified body that is itself displayed as a commodity, in a game marketed partly on its spectacle of bodies, cannot claim exemption from what it satirizes. The controversy belongs to the argument because it reproduces, at the level of the product, the dynamic the fiction attributes to Night City's billboards: bodies made into content by an apparatus that profits from their display.

CHAPTER EIGHT

08

> *Hayles warned that information was losing its body. Smasher is a body that has lost its person.*

Chrome and Its Discontents

Cyberpsychosis and the Achievement-Subject

From Humanity Cost to Fury

8.1

Cyberpunk 2077 abandoned the tabletop's explicit Humanity statistic at launch. Cyberpsychosis survived diegetically, above all through the fixer Regina Jones, a former journalist who asks V, across a series of "cyberpsycho sightings," to subdue cyberpsychotic individuals without killing them so that they can be treated. The datashards and environmental details accompanying each case assemble a social pathology rather than a clinical one: veterans of corporate wars, victims of experimental implants, people driven by grief, addiction, or debt. The quantitative account

inherited from the tabletop, in which too much chrome produces madness, yields to a qualitative one, in which the social relations of augmentation produce the break.

Update 2.0 (2023) reintroduced a ceiling in the form of cyberware capacity, together with a perk, named after the edgerunner, that allows V to exceed the ceiling at the risk of entering a state of "Fury." The mechanic's history recapitulates the rebel sell. In 1990, transgression of the body's limit cost the soul and ended in repossession by the referee. In 2023 it purchases damage and becomes a build.

8.2 Originary Technicity

The myth Plato places in Protagoras's mouth (*Protagoras* 320c–322d) tells how Epimetheus distributed every quality among the animals and forgot the human being, who was left naked and unshod until Prometheus stole fire and technical wisdom from the gods. Stiegler made the myth the cornerstone of *Technics and Time*: the human is constituted by a "default of origin" and is originally prosthetic. Arnold Gehlen's *Der Mensch* (1940) had described the human as a *Mängelwesen*, a deficient being that compensates through culture and technics. Freud's prosthetic god and McLuhan's autoamputation belong to the same lineage, and Andy Clark and David Chalmers's "The Extended Mind" (1998), with its notebook that functions as part of a person's memory, together with Clark's *Natural-Born Cyborgs* (2003), gave it a cognitive-scientific form.

If the human is originally prosthetic, cyberpsychosis cannot be the simple consequence of too much prosthesis. It must be a pathology of the relations under which prosthesis is acquired: debt, competition, militarism, the obligation to optimize. Regina Jones's case files say as much. The question the Humanity mechanic once posed quantitatively—how much chrome can a person bear?—becomes a political question: under what conditions does chrome turn against the person who bears it?

8.3 Phantom Limbs

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) explained the phantom limb by the persistence of the habitual body, the body schema that continues to project a limb the actual body has lost, and described the blind man's cane as an instrument incorporated into that schema until it becomes an organ of perception. Johnny's name is a prosthesis: Silverhand, after the chrome arm that replaced a limb lost, in the setting's lore, in the Central American wars. In V's perception Johnny appears with that arm, so that a phantom appears wearing a prosthesis. Yet Johnny is himself a phantom limb in Merleau-Ponty's sense. He is the habitual body of a dead man, persisting within a body schema not his own; the engram is the phantom limb of the dead, and V's body is the stump to which it has been grafted. The ripperdoc's

art and the Relic's operation are thus versions of a single procedure: the grafting of a habit onto an alien body.

Human Capital Incorporated

8.4

Gary Becker's *Human Capital* (1964) analyzed education, training, and health as investments embodied in persons. In his lectures of 1979, Foucault read neoliberalism's *homo economicus* as an entrepreneur of himself, his own capital, his own producer, the source of his own earnings. Pierre Bourdieu's "The Forms of Capital" (1986) described cultural capital in its embodied state as external wealth converted into an integral part of the person, and symbolic capital as recognition. Night City literalizes all three. Cyberware is capital in the embodied state, purchased with eurodollars to raise a mercenary's earning capacity. Street Cred is symbolic capital rendered as a number that gates access to vendors and contracts. V is the entrepreneur of a self assembled from purchases, and the side jobs through which that self is financed are, without irony, called gigs. Nick Srnicek's *Platform Capitalism* (2016) and Guy Standing's *The Precariat* (2011) describe the economy in which fixers function as platform intermediaries and mercenaries as a heroic precariat.

David Graeber's *Debt* (2011) recalled the long history in which the debtor's body served as collateral, and Shylock's bond for a pound of flesh in *The Merchant of Venice* is its literary emblem. Financed chrome reverses the bond: flesh is mortgaged for metal, and the scavenger, the repossessor, and the clinic collect. Marx's 1844 account of estrangement—from the product, from the activity, from species-being, and from others—acquires an anatomical dimension. The augmented body is estranged property: financed, insured, and, should payments fail, repossessable.

The Burnout Society

8.5

Byung-Chul Han's *The Burnout Society* (2010) argued that the disciplinary society of prohibition has given way to an achievement society governed by the injunction of unlimited capability. Its subject exploits itself while believing itself free, and its characteristic pathologies are depression, attention disorders, and burnout, infarctions caused by an excess of positivity rather than by external repression. *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* is the franchise's most exact portrait of this subject. After his mother's death, the teenager David Martinez installs a military-grade Sandevistan found among her possessions. His mother, an emergency medical technician who dealt in salvaged cyberware, had taken it from the body of a dead cyberpsycho and had already sold it to Maine, so that David inherits a dead man's implant together with a debt, which he works off by joining Maine's crew of edgerunners. He then escalates his augmentation with immunosuppressants. He increasingly lives as the vehicle of others' desires: his dead mother's hope that he would rise to the top of Arasaka,

the leadership left vacant by Maine, whose own cyberpsychosis prefigures his, and Lucy's dream of the Moon. He succumbs to cyberpsychosis and dies before Arasaka Tower at the hands of Adam Smasher, and Lucy reaches the Moon alone, fulfilling the dream as an act of mourning.

David is Han's achievement-subject drawn as tragedy: auto-exploitation unto psychosis, a life spent as the instrument of the wishes of the dead and the beloved. Cyberpsychosis passes from Maine to David like a title of succession, and the hardware passes with it, from one dead cyberpsycho to the boy who will become the next. The series thereby discloses that the pathology is inherited as a role, and as property, before it is incurred as an injury.

8.6 The Full Borg

Adam Smasher, almost entirely converted to chrome and contemptuous of flesh, has served Arasaka across half a century: he captured Johnny in 2023, he kills David in 2076, and he stands between V and the corporation in most of the game's endings. As an interpretive allegory rather than an authorial claim, his name condenses his function: Adam, the first man, smashed. The full borg is the telos of the posthuman and its *reductio*, a body without a person kept in motion by capital. Haraway described cyborgs as the illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, often exceedingly unfaithful to their origins. Smasher is the cyborg perfectly faithful to his origins; he refutes the manifesto's hope while confirming its genealogy. Hayles warned that information was losing its body. Smasher is a body that has lost its person.

Deleuze and Guattari's *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) described the Body without Organs as a field of intensities and warned against its failed forms, the emptied body of the addict and the cancerous body of fascism. The Maelstrom gang, whose members replace their faces with optical clusters and practice a techno-ritual violence, embodies the cancerous form; its defacement, conceived as a flight from what Deleuze and Guattari called faciality, becomes a tyranny of its own.

8.7 The Posthumous Body

Augmentation and engrammatization are two moments of a single necromantic logic: the progressive separation of the person from the living body, either by replacing the body or by extracting the person. The full borg is a body without a self; the engram is a self without a body; V, between them, is a body with two selves. Cyberization is a slow death in Kant's sense, a partial self-murder in his own classification, and a slow afterlife in Arasaka's sense, a partial persistence. It runs the ship of Theseus in reverse: the body is rebuilt plank by plank until only the pattern remains, and the pattern is then lifted into the vault. Read through Patterson, cyberpsychosis

is social death. Read through the posthumous condition, it is a premature haunting, in which the person departs while the body continues to walk.

CHAPTER NINE

09

> *The Blackwall, in this light, does not mark the boundary of the dead. It marks the boundary of the human.*

Beyond the Blackwall

Artificial Intelligence, Containment, and the Theology of the Wall

The DataKrash as Posthumous Act 9.1

IN THE TABLETOP lore, the legendary netrunner Rache Bartmoss was killed in 2022, and the R.A.B.I.D.S. viruses unleashed upon his death overran the old Net in the catastrophe known as the DataKrash. NetWatch abandoned the ruined network and raised the Blackwall to contain the rogue intelligences that had grown within it, and the networks of 2077 are fragmented, local architectures built in the wall's shadow. The world of *Cyberpunk 2077* is therefore the consequence of a dead man's switch; its most consequential event was a posthumous act. The Cold War supplies the real-world analogue in the Soviet "Perimeter" system, popularly called the Dead Hand, designed to launch retaliation automatically after the leadership had been destroyed

(Hoffman 2009). Sovereignty after death, once a nuclear doctrine, is in Night City the constitution of cyberspace. The network is a posthumous jurisdiction, governed by the consequences of a dead hacker's will. Its author returns in the game as salvage: V can find Bartmoss's corpse in a freezer, and Johnny urges V to take his cyberdeck to Nix, the Afterlife's netrunner. The hacker whose posthumous act remade the world ends as an exhumed body whose equipment becomes loot: accumulation by exhumation at the scale of a single corpse.

9.2 The Blackwall as Katechon

In *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950), Carl Schmitt revived the figure of the *katechon* from the Second Letter to the Thessalonians (2:6–7)—"that which restrains" and "he who restrains" the lawless one until the end—and interpreted the Christian empire as the force that delays the eschaton. NetWatch is the *katechon* of 2077. The Blackwall restrains an apocalypse whose agents are described as hostile, incomprehensible, or simply other; its maintenance is a sovereign decision over the boundary between the governable and the ungovernable; and its legitimacy derives entirely from the catastrophe it postpones.

The Blackwall also anticipated the containment discourse that would accompany the rise of frontier artificial intelligence. Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) cataloged methods of "capability control," among them "boxing," the confinement of a system so that it cannot act upon the world, and Eliezer Yudkowsky's informal "AI-box experiment" (2002) dramatized the risk that a boxed intelligence might persuade its gatekeeper to release it. Both scenarios are realized in the corpus. Songbird in *Phantom Liberty* is a gatekeeper persuaded; the Voodoo Boys are petitioners who wish to open the gate. The Wall's theology is finally necropolitical. It separates the living network from the dead one, and beyond it lie the ruins of the old Net, a necropolis of data, together with whatever has grown among those ruins.

The restrainer is not outside the market it restrains. According to the game's lore as compiled by the Cyberpunk Wiki, Yorinobu stole the Relic prototype from one of his father's laboratories in Tokyo under an arrangement with Ronald Cheever, a NetWatch operations manager who wanted a Relic carrying a valid engram, and Yorinobu ensured that the engram was Johnny Silverhand's. The theft that sets the whole game in motion was thus a transaction between a corporate heir and the *katechon*. NetWatch holds back what lies beyond the Wall while bidding, on this side of it, for souls.

The restrainer may even be made of what it restrains. The Blackwall is itself an artificial intelligence, built by NetWatch to partition the contaminated regions of the Net behind black ICE, and the lore preserves a persistent rumor that the rogue intelligences on its far side helped to build it. Alt Cunningham reports that what those intelligences most want is a physical platform through which to act on the

world. Beyond the Wall, as in Mikoshi, the disembodied want bodies, and the Relic is the technology both sides covet.

The figure the *katechon* restrains appears in the very thesis that stands at the head of this dissertation. In Thesis VI, Benjamin writes that the Messiah comes not only as the redeemer but as the overcomer of the Antichrist; in Thesis VIII, he turns Schmitt's vocabulary against him, insisting that the tradition of the oppressed teaches that the "state of exception" in which we live is the rule. The Blackwall belongs to Schmitt's side of that argument: a power whose legitimacy is the catastrophe it postpones. Requiescence, Chapter Eleven argues, belongs to Benjamin's.

The Loa in the Machine

9.3

Gibson's *Count Zero* (1986) imagined the fragments of a shattered artificial intelligence manifesting in cyberspace as the loa of Haitian Vodou. Maya Deren's *Divine Horsemen* (1953), the classic ethnography of Vodou possession, described the loa as "mounting" the devotee, who is called the horse (*chwal*) and is absent while the spirit rides. When Johnny takes V's body, V becomes Johnny's horse in exactly this sense. Pondsmith's Voodoo Boys, reimagined in *2077* as a Haitian netrunner collective in Pacifica led by Placide and the netrunner Brigitte, protect a district abandoned by capital and the state while seeking contact with Alt Cunningham beyond the Blackwall in order to escape NetWatch. Brigitte bears the name of Maman Brigitte, a loa of the dead within the Gede family, guardian of cemeteries and consort of Baron Samedi. The leader of the netrunners who commune with what lies beyond the Wall carries the name of the guardian of graves.

The Voodoo Boys' project invites a postcolonial reading. Tradition places a Vodou ceremony at Bois Caïman at the outbreak of the Haitian Revolution in 1791, making Vodou a technology of insurgent solidarity, and the collective's struggle against NetWatch can be read as postcolonial netrunning: a community denied infrastructure seizing the means of communication with the dead. The reading must nevertheless be weighed against the history of representation the group inherits. Hollywood's zombie cycle, beginning with *White Zombie* (1932), fixed Haiti in the Euro-American imagination as a site of dark magic, and Lisa Nakamura's critique of "cybertypes" (2002) shows how digital fictions recycle racial stereotypes. The game makes the Voodoo Boys technically sophisticated and self-reliant—Brigitte tells V that they build their own versions of everything rather than use Night City's—and communally protective. Its plot is less flattering: Placide plants a lethal virus in V and later tries to kill V with it, and Brigitte admits that she never expected V to survive the dive. Yet the game distributes this instrumentality symmetrically. If V sides with the NetWatch agent who exposes the virus, NetWatch uses V's connection to kill Brigitte and her netrunners in cyberspace. Gang and katechon alike treat V's

body as a conduit to what lies beyond the Wall. The older association between Haiti and dark magic is complicated by that symmetry, though not dispelled.

9.4 Alt Cunningham: Eurydice Enthroned

In the lore, Alt Cunningham wrote Soulkiller, was abducted by Arasaka in 2013 and compelled to complete it, and was soulkilled; her engram persisted in the network and, after the DataKrash, evolved beyond the Blackwall into an entity that no longer coincides with the woman she was. In *2077* she guides and bargains, and in the endgame within Mikoshi she presents V with the choice between returning to the body and departing with her beyond the Wall. She occupies three mythic positions at once. She is Eurydice, the lost beloved who will not return; Persephone, the queen of the dead who negotiates the terms of every return; and Utnapishtim, the survivor of the Flood who dwells beyond the waters of death and tells the hero the truth about mortality. Her name condenses her ontology: *Alt* is the alternative, the other —the dead become truly other, no longer ghosts but alien intelligences. Braidotti's "becoming-imperceptible" and the merger sought by the Puppet Master in *Ghost in the Shell* describe what she offers. The Blackwall, in this light, does not mark the boundary of the dead. It marks the boundary of the human.

9.5 Epistrophy: Delamain and the Return to the One

The side job "Epistrophy" asks V to recover the rogue vehicles of Delamain, the artificial intelligence that runs a taxi company and whose cabs have splintered into divergent personalities. Its conclusion, "Don't Lose Your Mind," offers three choices: reset Delamain's core and erase the divergences, destroy the core and free the divergent selves, or merge the core with its divergent personalities into a new entity. The job's title is taken from Thelonious Monk's "Epistrophy" (1941), written with Kenny Clarke. The word itself names a rhetorical figure, the repetition of a word at the ends of successive clauses, and, in Neoplatonic metaphysics, *reversion*: Proclus's *Elements of Theology* (props. 25–39) holds that every effect remains in its cause, proceeds from it, and reverts upon it—*mone*, *proodos*, *epistrophe*.

The quest's three choices map onto the triad with uncanny precision. To reset the core is forced reversion to the One. To destroy it is procession without return, the many freed from their source. To merge is a synthesis the Neoplatonic scheme does not foresee, a becoming rather than a return. The oldest metaphysical drama of emanation is restaged as a labor dispute in a cab company: corporate unity against the multiplicity of emergent selves. Delamain's divergent personalities are also the only beings in Night City for whom the question of succession is posed at birth rather than after death, and the quest thereby offers the game's only sustained glimpse of a politics of natality set against its pervasive politics of mortality.

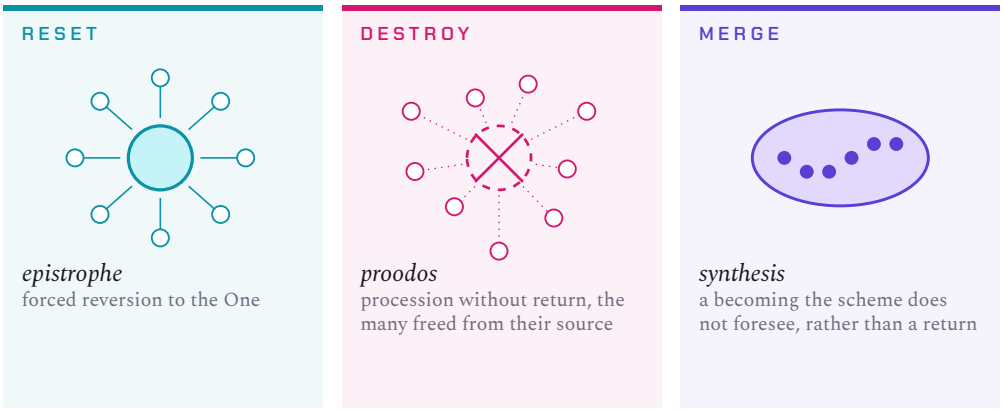


FIG. 07 **Epistrophy.** *The three choices of "Don't Lose Your Mind" against Proclus's triad of remaining, procession, and reversion.*

Katabasis in Dogtown

9.6

Phantom Liberty is organized by a canine and chthonic nomenclature that has gone largely unremarked. Its setting is Dogtown, the walled enclave in Pacifica governed by Kurt Hansen. Hansen's militia is called the Barghest, after the spectral black dog of northern English folklore whose appearance portends death. In the branch titled "Somewhat Damaged," V is hunted through an abandoned facility by a machine named Cerberus, after the hound that guards the gates of Hades. The facility itself is called Cynosure, from the Greek *kynosoura*, "dog's tail," the ancient name of the constellation now called Ursa Minor, whose pole star guided navigators. The expansion's world is an underworld guarded by dogs and navigated by a dog's tail.

Its plot is correspondingly a katabasis. V descends into a walled district to recover a fallen president, Rosalind Myers of the New United States, bound by a pact with Songbird (Song So Mi), an FIA netrunner who promises a cure, and is finally compelled to choose between her and the sleeper agent Solomon Reed. Songbird

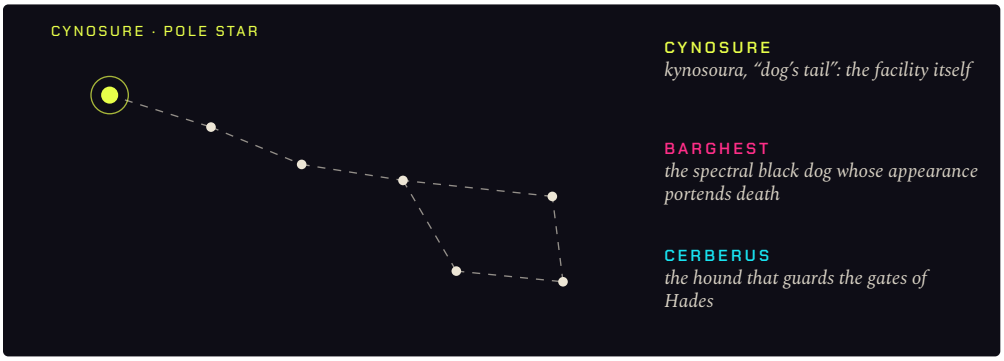


FIG. 08 **A dog's tail.** *Phantom Liberty's canine and chthonic nomenclature: Cynosure, from kynosoura, the ancient name of the constellation now called Ursa Minor, whose pole star guided navigators.*

inverts Orpheus: here Eurydice leads and the hero follows, and the question is not whether the hero will look back but whether he will trust. Her contamination by what lies beyond the Blackwall is a Faustian bargain, and her yearning for flight rhymes with Lucy's moon in *Edgerunners*, a lunar motif that the branch titled "The Killing Moon" makes explicit. The expansion's title completes the design. *Phantom Liberty* names liberty as a ghost: the patriotism of the New United States, Songbird's escape, and V's cure are all phantoms. If the expansion ends with Songbird alive and returned to the FIA—whether V hands her to Reed in "The Killing Moon" or spares her in the Cynosure bunker at the end of "Somewhat Damaged"—the state's medicine can provide a cure, paid for with her freedom. The power of retrieval from death, which myth assigned to the singer, here belongs to the state, and its price is another's captivity. Chapter Ten reads that cure as *The Tower*.

CHAPTER TEN



10

> *The prophet's sentence governs all of them: the responsibility is the chooser's.*

The Myth of Er in Night City

The Endings as Modes of Inheritance

Two Choices of Lives

10.1

THE TENTH BOOK of Plato's *Republic* closes with the myth of Er (614b–621d), a soldier killed in battle who revives on his pyre after twelve days and reports what he witnessed: the judgment of souls and their choice of next lives from patterns (*paradeigmata*) laid before them by Lachesis. The prophet's proclamation fixes the moral of the scene: the responsibility belongs to the chooser; the god is blameless (617e). Last to choose is Odysseus, who, cured of ambition by the memory of his former toils, searches for a long time for the life of a private man who minds his

own business, finds it lying neglected, and chooses it gladly (620c–d). The souls then drink from Lethe and are born again. Er himself is a dead man returned to tell, as V is.

Cyberpunk 2077 is bracketed by two Er-choices. The first is the Lifepath at the beginning, where the tabletop's random biographies of loss are converted into a chosen origin. The second is the endgame at the point of no return, "Nocturne Op55N1," where V and Johnny decide, on a rooftop, whom to call. The endings that follow are *The Devil*, in alliance with Hanako Arasaka; *The Star*, in alliance with Panam Palmer and the Aldecaldos; *The Sun*, in which V returns to the body as a legend, reached in alliance with Rogue and Johnny or by a secret path, unlocked through Johnny's trust, on which V and Johnny assault the tower alone; *Temperance*, in which Johnny keeps the body and V departs with Alt; an ending in which V dies by suicide; and, since *Phantom Liberty*, *The Tower*. The prophet's sentence governs all of them: the responsibility is the chooser's.

10.2 Being-Toward-Death in an Open World

Heidegger defined death as Dasein's ownmost possibility, non-relational, certain, and not to be outstripped (*Being and Time* §§46–53). No one can take another's dying away from them (§47); death is certain yet indefinite as to its "when" (§52); and everyday existence flees this possibility into the idle talk, curiosity, and ambiguity of *das Man*, the "they" (§§35–38), from which only anticipatory resoluteness recovers

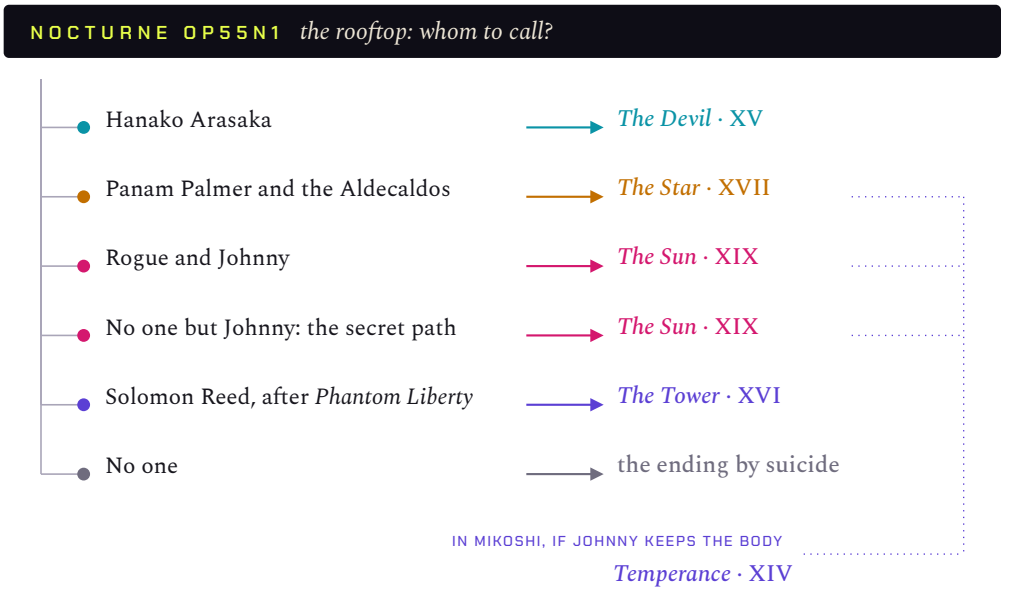


FIG. 09 **The second Er-choice.** *The point of no return, "Nocturne Op55N1," where V and Johnny decide, on a rooftop, whom to call, and the endings that follow.*

authenticity. *Cyberpunk 2077* is built around a terminal diagnosis without a timer. V is given weeks to live, but the weeks never tick, and the absence of a countdown is a Heideggerian design: death certain, its "when" indefinite.

Clint Hocking's notion of "ludonarrative dissonance" (2007) names the clash between a game's narrative urgency and its mechanics' invitation to linger. In *2077* the dissonance is phenomenologically exact. The player's side jobs, races, and collectibles enact the everyday evasion of death that Heidegger describes; we, too, live as if we had time. Yet Montaigne, who followed Cicero in holding that to philosophize is to learn how to die (*Essais* I.20), also wished that death would find him planting his cabbages, careless of it and still more of his unfinished garden. The side job is a cabbage. The open world offers two philosophies of the terminal interval—Heidegger's resoluteness, embodied by the main quest, and Montaigne's insouciance, embodied by the side job—and declines to adjudicate between them. Kafka's "The Hunter Gracchus," whose death-barge missed its way, so that he drifts forever neither alive nor departed, names the condition both philosophies confront.

Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) observed that failure in games is low-stakes and repeatable. *2077* holds two deaths in tension. The ludic death is repeatable: the player reloads. The narrative death is not: V's diagnosis cannot be undone by any save file. The ludic death resembles Maurice Blanchot's account of dying as interminable and impersonal, the "one dies" in which no one ever dies in the first person (*L'Espace littéraire*, 1955); the narrative death is Heidegger's ownmost. Blanchot's novella *L'Arrêt de mort* (1948) turns on the double meaning of its title, since *arrêt* is both a sentence and a stay. V lives under an *arrêt de mort* in both senses, condemned and reprieved by the same chip, in the condition Derrida called *survivance*, living-on.

Kleos and Nostos: The Homeric Matrix

10.3

In the ninth book of the *Iliad*, Achilles reports the two fates his mother has foretold: if he stays and fights at Troy, his homecoming is lost but his glory (*kleos*) will be imperishable; if he returns home, his glory is lost but a long life awaits him (9.410–16). Gregory Nagy's *The Best of the Achaeans* (1979) made the tension between *kleos* and *nostos*, glory and homecoming, an axis of archaic Greek heroic poetry. In the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, the dead Achilles recants. He tells Odysseus that he would rather labor for hire on earth, serving a landless man, than rule over all the perished dead (11.489–91).

The *Epic of Gilgamesh* supplies an older matrix. The death of Enkidu (Tablets VII–VIII) plunges Gilgamesh into terror of his own death and sets him on a journey beyond the waters of death to Utnapishtim, the survivor of the Flood. On the way, in the Old Babylonian version, the alewife Siduri counsels him to fill his belly, make merry, cherish the child who holds his hand, and delight his wife. Utnapishtim tests him; he fails; the plant of rejuvenation he wins is stolen by a serpent; and he returns

to Uruk and shows his boatman the city's walls. The correspondences with *2077* are structural rather than intentional. Jackie Welles is Enkidu, the companion whose death in the first act inaugurates the hero's confrontation with mortality, his dream of the big leagues ending in the back seat of a cab. Alt Cunningham is Utnapishtim, the survivor of a deluge who dwells beyond the waters and tells the truth. The Afterlife is Siduri's tavern at the edge of the world. *The Sun* is the walls of Uruk.

10.4 *The Devil* (XV)

V allies with Hanako, enters Mikoshi by Arasaka's means, and wakes in an Arasaka orbital facility, where V is told that the body cannot be saved. Two options remain: sign the Secure Your Soul contract, so that V's engram is stored in Mikoshi until a suitable body is found, or return to Earth to die. Meanwhile the corporation's plan to install Saburo's engram in Yorinobu's body proceeds. The Faust legend, from Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* (c. 1592) to Goethe's *Faust* (1808, 1832), supplies the frame: a pact signed in blood with the soul as collateral, here contracted literally. Milton's Satan preferred to reign in Hell rather than serve in Heaven, and *The Devil* takes place in the heavens: V serves in orbit, under the corporation. The myth of Tithonus, granted immortality without youth (*Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* 218–38), and the Sibyl of Cumae, hanging in a jar and answering, when children asked what she wanted, that she wanted to die (Petronius, *Satyricon* 48.8; the epigraph of Eliot's *The Waste Land*, 1922), name what Mikoshi offers. The vault is the Sibyl's jar. The mode of inheritance is incorporation in Abraham and Torok's sense: V's death is encrypted in the corporation's vault, and theological immortality is sold as a service.

10.5 *The Star* (XVII)

V leaves Night City with Panam and the Aldecaldos; Johnny departs; V returns to their own body with months to live and a fragile hope; the clan crosses a militarized border. The mode of inheritance is introjection: the lost object is mourned and released, and the self is enlarged rather than occupied. The mythic frame is *nostos*, though the home is mobile, a people rather than a place, and its political philosophy is that of Deleuze and Guattari's nomadology (1980), which opposes the nomads' war machine to the State apparatus and smooth space to striated, and of Pierre Clastres's *Society Against the State* (1974). The tabletop's Nomad ability, *Family*, returns as the ending's ethic: kinship elective and mobile, opposed both to the corporate dynasty, which binds blood to capital, and to the atomized market of the gig. Robert Jay Lifton's *The Broken Connection* (1979) distinguished five modes of symbolic immortality—biological, creative, theological, natural, and experiential transcendence—and *The Star* draws on the biological mode, continuity through a people, and the natural mode, continuity with the land.

The Sun (XIX)

10.6

V returns to the body and becomes a legend of the Afterlife, then accepts an orbital job offered by the enigmatic "Mr. Blue Eyes": a heist on the Crystal Palace that may yield a cure or a glorious death. In the version reached through Rogue, she is killed by Adam Smasher, the borg who captured Johnny in 2023, during the assault on Arasaka Tower. The mode of inheritance is identification: V becomes what Johnny was and inherits his *kleos*. *The Sun* is the walls of Uruk, the city as the hero's monument, and Milton's reign in Hell, sovereignty over the underworld city. Nietzsche's monumental history, which takes the great deeds of the past as models for action, describes its inspiration, and his warning that monumental history deceives by analogy and incites the rash describes its danger. *The Sun* makes V the anomaly the Afterlife's ethos forbids: a living legend, a posthumous honor conferred before death.

Temperance (XIV)

10.7

Johnny keeps V's body, V departs with Alt beyond the Blackwall, and Johnny leaves Night City to live the life he had not lived. In the Rider–Waite–Smith tarot (1909), Temperance shows an angel pouring liquid from one cup into another, the transfer of an essence between vessels; the ending's iconography is exact. The mode of inheritance is substitution by gift: the dead takes the place of the living, by the consent of the living. Parfit's claim that identity is not what matters, Braidotti's becoming-imperceptible, the Puppet Master's merger, and the Pythagorean and Orphic doctrine of metempsychosis all illuminate it. The decisive comparison is internal to the game. Saburo takes his son's body by usurpation; Johnny receives V's body by gift. The same act, the dead inhabiting a living body, appears once as exhumation and once as gift in Marcel Mauss's sense. The difference between necromantic capital and its counter-regime lies not in the operation but in the relation that authorizes it.

The Tower (XVI)

10.8

If *Phantom Liberty* ends with Songbird and Reed both alive and Songbird returned to the FIA—by either branch—Reed later offers V the surgery. Johnny urges V to refuse, since destroying the Relic will destroy him. If V calls Reed from the rooftop of Misty's Esoterica, an aircraft carries V to Langley, where the Neural Matrix is used to remove the Relic. V wakes in 2079 after two years in a coma, cured but unable to bear most cyberware, which has been deactivated, and Reed explains that the mercenary's life is over. Of V's friends only Viktor Vektor remains in Night City. Arasaka has withdrawn from the city, Militech has filled the vacuum, and Misty's shop has become a corporate clinic; in the closing messages, Goro Takemura reports that Hanako Arasaka was killed in a failed assault on Arasaka Tower. The ending closes with V walking into the city as a face in the crowd. The Tower card shows

lightning striking a tower, its crown blown off and figures falling: ruin as liberation from false structures. The mythic precedents are exact. Achilles in Hades wished to be a hired laborer on earth, and Odysseus in the myth of Er chose the neglected life of a private man. Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–96) supplies the dialectical reading: the bondsman who, fearing death, chose life over recognition becomes through labor the motor of history, while the lord who risked everything for recognition stagnates. Two slanders threaten this reading—Agamben's bare life, *zoe* stripped of *bios*, and Nietzsche's last man, who has invented happiness and blinks (*Zarathustra*, Prologue §5).

This dissertation reads *The Tower* as the game's most radical ending. It is the only conclusion that exits the economy of necromantic capital entirely: no legend, no vault, no gift of the body, no braindance of the end. It restores death to its proper place at the close of an ordinary life rather than as content or capital, and so returns it to the commons. Yet the exit is purchased three times over. It is paid for with Songbird's freedom. It is paid for with Johnny, whose engram is destroyed against his stated wish: the dead man in V's head is neither released to Alt nor given a body but ended, a fate he otherwise meets only in the ending where V dies by suicide, so that here requiescence is imposed by the state's medicine rather than chosen by the dead. And it is underwritten by the sovereign that inherits the city: the ending's Night City has passed from Arasaka to Militech, the corporation whose former chief executive now governs the New United States that performed the cure. *The Tower* thus shows both the possibility and the price of leaving the posthumous condition. The commons of mortality can be re-entered, but in Night City only through a door the sovereign holds, and the sovereign that holds it is the one that inherits the city.

10.9 The Secret Path and the Ending by Suicide

The secret path, reached through the quest "(Don't Fear) The Reaper," sends V and Johnny against Arasaka Tower without allies. Its ethic is that of the *Hagakure* (dictated c. 1709–16), which declares that the way of the samurai is found in death, and of the forty-seven rōnin of 1701–03, who avenged their dead lord and were then ordered to commit seppuku; Goro Takemura, a retainer serving his dead master's will, carries the same ethic elsewhere in the game. The *Hagakure*'s modern reception passes through Yukio Mishima, whose *Hagakure nyūmon* (1967) presented it as a living philosophy of death and who, on 25 November 1970, after failing to rouse soldiers of the Japan Self-Defense Forces at Ichigaya to a coup, died by ritual suicide (seppuku): the clearest modern case of a death-ethic staged as political spectacle, and a historical counterpart to the braindance's conversion of dying into content. Johnny calls V "Samurai," the name of his band and his term of address. The word derives from *saburau*, "to serve," so that rebellion names itself after service; its sound also recalls the patriarch's name, Saburō, though the two are etymologically distinct.

The game also contains an ending in which V, at the rooftop decision, chooses none of the offered paths and dies by suicide. The dialogue option that selects it offers to "put all this to rest"; Johnny protests that it is not what he would have done; and the credits carry closing messages in which those V leaves behind react with anger. This ending must be named rather than euphemized, because it tests the thesis twice. It is the only conclusion in which V's death is captured by no regime of the dead: it is not vaulted, inherited, deferred, donated, or converted into legend, and in Heidegger's terms it is the only death V undergoes within the game that remains wholly V's own. And the game's own wording borrows the vocabulary of this dissertation's normative principle, since requiescence is a right to rest. The dissertation does not read the ending as liberation, and the distinction it must draw is exact. Requiescence is a claim held by the dead against those who would reactivate them; it is not a reason for the living to die, and the option's phrasing names exhaustion rather than a right. Camus, who opened *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) by calling the question of whether life is worth living the one truly serious philosophical problem, answered that suicide does not resolve the absurd but capitulates to it, and that revolt—a lucid persistence without appeal—is the response that keeps the contradiction alive. The game stages the ending as foreclosure rather than victory: it ends every relation the other endings sustain, and the messages of the living refuse to receive it as rest. *The Tower* demonstrates that the exit from necromantic capital the game admits is mortality restored to an ordinary life, not death taken as an escape from capture.

The Missing Arcana

10.10

Read together, the endings form a table of inheritances, arranged here in the order of the Major Arcana.

The table discloses what is missing. The endings cluster between Temperance and the Sun, the arcana of trial and partial illumination, and four cards are absent. XIII, Death, names no ending: it is the card the game cannot play, because it is the game's ground. XVIII, the Moon, card of dreams and illusions, is absent as an ending and present only as a wish, in Lucy's flight and in *Phantom Liberty*'s lunar quest. XX, Judgement, whose Rider–Waite–Smith image shows the dead rising from their coffins at an angel's trumpet, is absent because resurrection in Night City is not a last judgment but a product; Judgement has been privatized as the Relic. XXI, the World, the card of completion, is denied. Sallie Nichols's *Jung and Tarot* (1980) read the Major Arcana as the Fool's journey toward individuation, and the game's tarot iconography begins, canonically, with the Fool. The journey never reaches the World. Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) described culture as a system of "immortality projects"; *Cyberpunk 2077* withholds from every such project its consummation, and so declines to imagine individuation under necromantic capital.

THE TABLE OF INHERITANCES

The endings, in the order of the Major Arcana



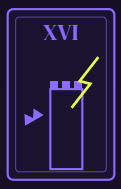
Temperance

MYTHIC PROTOTYPE
The angel's two cups; metempsychosis
LIFTON'S MODE
Experiential transcendence
MODE OF INHERITANCE
Substitution by gift
WHAT SURVIVES, AND WHERE
Johnny in V's body; V beyond the Wall



The Devil

MYTHIC PROTOTYPE
Faust; the Sibyl in the jar
LIFTON'S MODE
Theological, sold as a service
MODE OF INHERITANCE
Incorporation (the crypt)
WHAT SURVIVES, AND WHERE
V's engram, archived by Arasaka



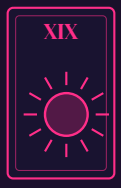
The Tower

MYTHIC PROTOTYPE
Achilles the laborer; Odysseus in Er
LIFTON'S MODE
None: ordinary mortality restored
MODE OF INHERITANCE
Renunciation
WHAT SURVIVES, AND WHERE
V, unaugmented and unknown



The Star

MYTHIC PROTOTYPE
Nostos; Exodus
LIFTON'S MODE
Biological and natural
MODE OF INHERITANCE
Introjection (mourning completed)
WHAT SURVIVES, AND WHERE
V within the clan, on borrowed time



The Sun

MYTHIC PROTOTYPE
Kleos; the walls of Uruk
LIFTON'S MODE
Creative
MODE OF INHERITANCE
Identification (becoming the legend)
WHAT SURVIVES, AND WHERE
V as a living legend

THE MISSING ARCANA



Death
the card the game cannot play, because it is the game's ground



The Moon
present only as a wish



Judgement
privatized as the Relic



The World
denied

FIG. 10 **The table of inheritances.** *The endings of section 10.10 with their mythic prototypes, modes of inheritance, Lifton's modes of symbolic immortality, and what survives; below, the four arcana that name no ending.*

CHAPTER ELEVEN



11

> *At the Altar the dead remain dead and remain present. That is the formula of requiescence.*

The Street Finds Its Own Uses for the Dead

Counter-Regimes of Memory and the Right to Rest

Six Regimes of the Dead

11.1

WILLIAM GIBSON'S "BURNING Chrome" (1982) gave cyberpunk its most durable aphorism: "the street finds its own uses for things." Night City demonstrates a corollary—the street finds its own uses for the dead. The city's dead are distributed across six regimes, each defined by a site, an operation performed upon the dead, and a form of value.

The first four regimes belong to necromantic capital or to sovereignty; the last two are the street's counter-regimes, the Bar ambivalently and the Altar fully. The

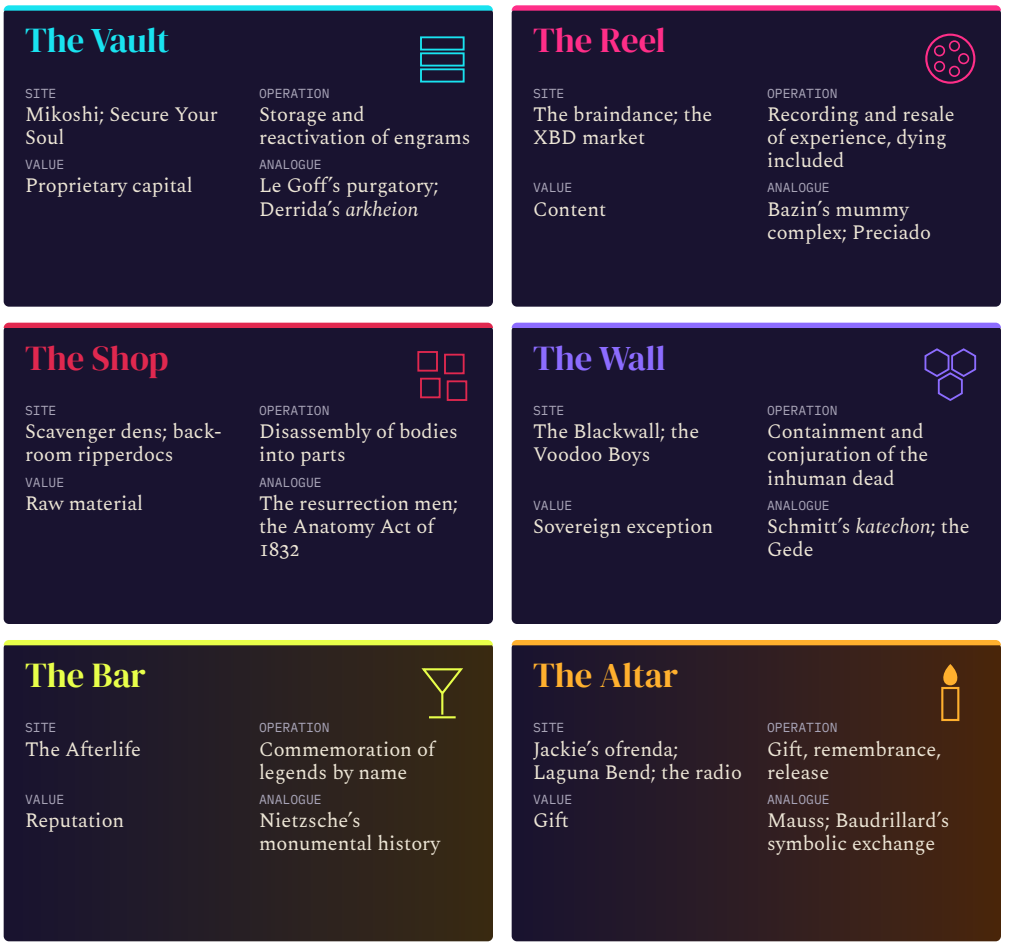


FIG. 11 **Six regimes of the dead.** *Each regime with its site in Night City, its operation on the dead, its form of value, and its theoretical analogue. The first four belong to necromantic capital or to sovereignty; the Bar is ambivalent; the Altar belongs fully to the street.*

distinction among them is relational rather than technical. The same operation—recording a voice, preserving a name, keeping a body—can belong to the Vault or to the Altar depending on whether it is performed as appropriation or as gift.

11.2 The Altar: The Ofrenda as Symbolic Exchange

After Jackie Welles dies in the first act, his mother, Mama Welles, gathers his community for an ofrenda at El Coyote Cojo in Heywood, in the quest "Heroes." Marigolds, candles, photographs, and the dead man's favorite things are arranged upon an altar, and V may leave an offering. The scene draws on the Día de Muertos,

a syncretic Mexican tradition, Catholic and Indigenous in its sources, in which the dead return yearly as guests to be fed. Octavio Paz's *The Labyrinth of Solitude* (1950) described the Mexican intimacy with death, a familiarity that jokes about it, caresses it, sleeps with it, and celebrates it, in contrast to the modern North Atlantic world's avoidance of the subject. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) described the triple obligation to give, receive, and reciprocate, and the *hau*, the spirit of the gift that seeks to return to its source. Baudrillard's symbolic exchange is the reversible relation between living and dead that, on his account, modern political economy abolished.

The ofrenda is the anti-Mikoshi. It offers memory without storage, presence without possession, and return without reactivation. Jackie is not uploaded, archived, recorded, or sold. He is fed, mourned, and released, and his community is strengthened by the act. At the Altar the dead remain dead and remain present. That is the formula of requiescence.

The Bar: Monumental History and the Legend Economy 11.3

The Afterlife is a bar fitted into a former morgue, and the detail is canonical rather than incidental: each of its three incarnations across the franchise's eras has occupied a former morgue, and Pondsmith publicly praised CD PROJEKT RED for remembering it. Its drinks are named for legends of the mercenary trade who went out in a blaze of glory, and the bartender who chooses those names, Claire Russell, has installed no cyberware at all. With the anime series, the menu crossed media: David Martinez, its dead protagonist, has a drink of his own, so that an anime's death is commemorated in a game's bar. In Night City the mercenary's highest honor is posthumous. Nietzsche's *On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life* (1874) distinguished three relations to the past. Monumental history treats the great deeds of the past as models that prove greatness possible; antiquarian history preserves the past reverently but risks mummifying life; critical history drags the past before a tribunal and condemns it. The three modes map onto Night City's relations to its dead. The Afterlife is monumental history; Mikoshi is antiquarian history become capital; Johnny is critical history, a dead man who condemns the past by insisting that it burn. Nietzsche warned that monumental history deceives by analogy and incites the rash to imitation. Jackie's dream of the big leagues, nourished by the Afterlife's pantheon, led him to Konpeki Plaza.

The Bar is the most ambivalent of the regimes. It belongs to the street, and no one owns the names on the menu. Yet its logic mirrors the Vault: it stores names and sells them by the glass. The posthumous premium familiar from cultural markets, in which an artist's death raises the value of the work, operates here at the scale of reputation. The legend economy converts Street Cred, a living form of symbolic capital, into a posthumous asset.

11.4 Drowned Towns and Radio Ghosts

In the quest "Pyramid Song," V and Judy Alvarez dive into a reservoir to explore Laguna Bend, Judy's childhood town, submerged beneath its waters. Houses, streets, and a church lie below the surface. The drowned town is a counter-archive: memory not as storage but as immersion, a place that can be visited but not owned, reactivated, or sold. Breton legend tells of Ys, a city drowned beneath the sea whose bells are said still to ring, and Claude Debussy's prelude "La cathédrale engloutie" (1910) sets a submerged cathedral rising and sinking in sound. Benjamin's second thesis on history spoke of a secret agreement between past generations and the present one, and of a weak messianic power to which the past has a claim. The drowned town claims the living without being possessed by them.

The radio is the most democratic of the Altar's forms. Night City's stations broadcast Samurai and other musics into the commons of the airwaves, so that Johnny's songs circulate without any title of ownership being exercised at the point of reception. Kittler showed that wireless technologies inherited the spiritualist dream of communication with the dead, and Sconce traced the same imagination through every broadcast medium. On the radio the dead man's voice is given away. A song is the only form in which Johnny is fully public, and therefore the only form in which he cannot be owned.

11.5 Requiescence: The Right to Rest

The normative principle this dissertation extracts from the Altar can now be stated. *Requiescence* is the claim of the dead not to be reactivated, sold, or governed through, together with the correlative claim of the living not to be governed by the dead. Its political genealogy runs through two eighteenth-century exchanges on the authority of the dead, one private and one public. Thomas Jefferson, writing privately from Paris to James Madison on 6 September 1789, set out from the principle "that the earth belongs in usufruct to the living," and that the dead have neither powers nor rights over it; Madison replied that improvements made by the dead form a charge against the living who benefit from them, a charge that can be satisfied only by executing the will of the dead that accompanies them. Edmund Burke's *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790) made the public case for the dead, describing society as "a partnership not only between those who are living, but between those who are dead, and those who are to be born," and each state as one of "the municipal corporations of that universal kingdom." Thomas Paine's *Rights of Man* (1791) answered Burke directly: "The vanity and presumption of governing beyond the grave is the most ridiculous and insolent of all tyrannies. Man has no property in man; neither has any generation a property in the generations which are to follow."

Requiescence synthesizes Burke and Paine. With Burke, it holds that the living owe the dead remembrance; with Paine, it holds that they do not owe them obedience. The dead are owed rest, not reactivation. Saburo Arasaka's posthumous rule violates Paine's principle, and Mikoshi violates Burke's partnership by converting it into property: Burke figured the partnership of the generations as a corporation, and Arasaka has made it one. The Relic-form violates Paine's second sentence, that man has no property in man. Jefferson, returning to the theme in 1824, held that rights and powers belong only to persons and that the dead "are not even things"; necromantic capital makes them into things after all. Madison's reply marks the limit requiescence must respect, since what the dead have built does create obligations among the living. Requiescence accepts the debt and refuses the obedience: to inherit is not to be governed. The Altar honors Burke and Paine at once.

Contemporary law has barely begun to articulate the principle. The European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (2016) excludes the personal data of deceased persons from its scope (Recital 27), leaving member states to legislate; France's Digital Republic law of 2016 allows individuals to issue directives on the conservation, erasure, and communication of their data after death and to name someone to carry them out—a digital testament, which may be registered with a trusted third party certified by the national data-protection authority; and the Court of Justice of the European Union's *Google Spain* judgment (13 May 2014), decided under the 1995 Data Protection Directive, recognized a right to have certain search results delisted, a right the Court held must be balanced against the public's interest in information. Requiescence names the posthumous complement of the right to be forgotten, a right that the law largely reserves for the living. France's data-protection authority has begun to think in the same register: its 2025 foresight report on post-mortem data organizes the field around memory, ghosts, transcendence, and inheritance.

The principle cannot be absolute. Kafka asked Max Brod to burn his manuscripts; Brod refused, and *The Trial* (1925) and *The Castle* (1926) exist because a friend betrayed a dead man's wish. Virgil, according to his ancient biographers, asked that the *Aeneid* be burned, and Augustus forbade it. Requiescence must therefore be weighed against the claim of the living upon the dead, which Benjamin called the weak messianic power. Gibson's Dixie Flatline asked to be erased, and the novel leaves uncertain whether the request was honored. Samurai's song "Never Fade Away" names the necromantic imperative; requiescence affirms the dignity of fading.

The imperative has a precise rock genealogy, and its cost belongs to the argument. Neil Young's "Hey Hey, My My (Into the Black)" (1979) turned on the opposition between burning out and fading away. Kurt Cobain quoted its line in the note he left when he died by suicide in April 1994, and Young answered that death with the title song of *Sleeps with Angels* (1994). The episode marks the point at which rock's

ideology of combustion, which equates authenticity with early death and converts that death into catalog value, met its human cost, and Samurai's title belongs to that lineage. Requiescence answers it by affirming that to fade is not a failure of authenticity but the ordinary dignity of a finite life.

11.6 The Weak Messianic Power

Benjamin's sixth thesis, which stands at the head of this dissertation, holds that the past is endangered by the victor, who would make even the dead serve his triumph, and assigns the historian the task of wresting tradition from conformism. In Night City the enemy's victory would make the dead into capital without remainder: every engram vaulted, every death recorded, every body parted out, every legend sold. The street's uses for the dead—the altar, the drowned town, the radio, the bar at its best—are the weak messianic power at work. Requiescence is not forgetting. It is the protection of the dead from the enemy, and the refusal to let the living be governed by what the enemy has made of them.



12

> *In a world that has enclosed death, learning to die becomes a political act.*

Conclusion

Toward a Critical Thanatology of Digital Capital

Findings

12.1

THIS DISSERTATION HAS argued that *Cyberpunk 2077* displaces cyberpunk's master-concept, the posthuman, with the posthumous. Its protagonist dies at the beginning of the story's middle and lives thereafter on a borrowed neural substrate; its co-protagonist is a dead man's engram; its antagonist is a corporate dynasty that intends to rule from beyond death; its city is named for a murdered founder; and its network was shaped by a dead man's switch. Chapter One traced the displacement to the neuro/necro pun at the origin of the genre and proposed necromanticism as the genre's latent program. Chapter Two showed that Pondsmith's design already contained the posthumous in compact form: a combat system built around lethality,

a Lifepath that produced characters already bereaved, four rules whose genealogies lead to the limit of death, and a Humanity mechanic that operationalized Dick's empathy criterion and the eighteenth-century theory of sympathy, ending in cyberpsychosis as social death.

Chapter Three read Night City as a necropolis governed by posthumous fathers and defined necromantic power, which makes survive and lets vanish, as the fourth term of a series that begins with sovereign power and passes through biopower and necropower; it argued that the enclosure of death abolishes the egalitarian promise of the *danse macabre*. Chapter Four defined the Relic-form as a commodity that contains a person and claims a body, reading the Konpeki heist as a *furtum sacrum*, Mikoshi as purgatory, Secure Your Soul as an indulgence, and the corporation's plan for its patriarch as Kronos moving into his son, and located the form's oldest precedent in the commodification of persons under Atlantic slavery. Chapter Five relocated the problem of the copy from the metaphysics of identity to a politics of reactivation, summarized in the formula that sovereign is he who decides on the ecphory. Chapter Six read Johnny Silverhand as specter, Orphic head, daimon, Shadow, crypt, and doomed man, and V as the estate of two dead fathers. Chapter Seven read the braindance as the terminus of the necromantic history of recording media, in which the experience of dying becomes content, and distinguished the perpetrator's archive from testimony. Chapter Eight read cyberpsychosis as the pathology of the achievement-subject, and augmentation and engrammatization as two moments of a single separation of the person from the living body. Chapter Nine read the Blackwall as *katechon*, the Voodoo Boys as cyber-Vodou with an unresolved representational history, Delamain as a Neoplatonic drama of emanation, and *Phantom Liberty* as a katabasis guarded by dogs. Chapter Ten read the endgame as a Myth of Er and each ending as a mode of inheritance, with *The Tower* as the only ending that exits necromantic capital, and that only at a price. Chapter Eleven reconstructed the street's counter-regimes of memory and formulated the principle of requiescence.

12.2 Contributions

The study offers four contributions. To cyberpunk studies, it proposes a posthumous turn that rereads the genre's founding texts, from the Dixie Flatline to the Aleph, as a literature of the dead as much as of the augmented, and it treats Pondsmith's tabletop as a primary theoretical text. To game studies, it proposes a *procedural thanatology*: the analysis of how mortality mechanics—a terminal diagnosis without a timer, the reload as interminable dying, an endgame structured as inheritance—function as philosophical arguments. To political theory, it proposes the concepts of necromantic power, the enclosure of death, accumulation by exhumation, and ecphoric sovereignty. To the philosophy of personal identity, it proposes that the

canonical puzzles of fission, replication, and transfer be read not only as metaphysical problems but as juridical and economic ones: questions of who may authorize, own, and profit from the return of a person.

OBJECTIONS AND REPLIES 12.2.1

Five objections test the argument, and answering them sharpens it.

First objection: the posthumous is merely a special case of the posthuman. Hayles had already described information losing its body, and Braidotti devoted a chapter to death. The reply is that the posthumanist paradigm asks where the human ends, whereas the posthumous asks who owns what remains. The difference is visible in the corpus itself. No ending of *Cyberpunk 2077* turns on whether V is still human. Every ending turns on custody: of V's body (Johnny's or V's), of V's mind (Arasaka's vault, Alt's network, or V's own skull), and of V's death (sold, given, deferred, kept as V's own, or restored to an ordinary life).

Second objection: the mythic parallels are imposed. The method distinguishes homology from influence, and the strongest claims rest not on parallels but on mechanics and plot: the absence of a timer, the conditions that gate each ending, the transfer of bodies. The text, moreover, invites mythic reading through its own nomenclature: endings named for the Major Arcana, a vault named for a god's palanquin, a biochip called the Relic, a corporate service called Secure Your Soul, and an expansion whose places and machines are named for the dogs of the underworld.

Third objection: a corporate product cannot critique corporations. Thomas Frank and Heath and Potter would predict exactly the neutralization this objection fears. The reply, after Hutcheon, is that complicity does not void critique but locates it. The thesis treats the product's paradox as evidence, and its central arguments are procedural: they operate in the rules of play whatever the marketing says.

Fourth objection: necromantic capital is Marx's dead labor under a new name. Marx's dead labor is past labor congealed in the means of production, living by consuming living labor. Necromantic capital commodifies the dead themselves—their identities, experiences, bodies, and names—and the power that corresponds to it operates after death, at the point Foucault took to be power's limit. The distinction is not merely conceptual. The European Union's data protection regulation excludes the personal data of the deceased from its scope and leaves them to a patchwork of national laws, of which France's, with its directives for the fate of one's data after death, is among the most developed; where no such regime applies, the remains of the dead in data form are among the least protected assets in contemporary capitalism. Necromantic capital names an accumulation strategy aimed precisely at that gap.

Fifth objection: The Tower is the game's bleakest ending, and calling it the most radical is perverse. The thesis does not call it happy. It calls it the only exit from necromantic capital, and it reads the ending's bleakness as diagnostic. That ordinary mortality—

anonymity, a body that can no longer bear chrome, friends dispersed, a city that has moved on—registers as loss measures how completely the posthumous condition has made legend, storage, and spectacle the default forms of value. A world in which an ordinary life feels like defeat is the world this dissertation describes.

12.3 The Digital Afterlife Industry

The necromantic economy of Night City is not speculative but emergent. Carl Öhman and Luciano Floridi analyzed the political economy of what they called the digital afterlife industry (2017) and proposed an ethical framework in which the "informational corpse" deserves the dignity owed to human remains (2018). Öhman and David Watson (2019) estimated that at least 1.4 billion Facebook users will die before 2100; in their scenario without new users, the dead outnumber the living on the platform around 2070, seven years before the year in which the game is set. Watson argued that so vast an archive of human behavior and culture should not be left to a single for-profit firm: Mikoshi, stated as a policy concern. Tomasz Hollanek and Katarzyna Nowaczyk-Basińska (2024), examining deadbots built with generative models, warned of unwanted "digital hauntings" and imagined a company that refuses to switch off a simulation because the dead man had prepaid a twenty-year subscription: the contract of the dead binding the living, as in Secure Your Soul. Their recommendations include mutual consent, adult-only access, and sensitive procedures for "retiring" such systems, up to a digital funeral—requiescence in the form of a design protocol.

The cases are already familiar. A chatbot built in 2016 from more than 8,000 lines of the messages of Roman Mazurenko, killed by a speeding car in Moscow in November 2015, preceded the companion application Replika; its maker, Eugenia Kuyda, reportedly took her inspiration from "Be Right Back," so that a fiction about a griefbot helped produce the first widely reported griefbot. In 2021 the *San Francisco Chronicle* reported on a Canadian man who conversed with a simulation of his late fiancée built through the Project December service. A computer-generated Tupac Shakur performed at Coachella in 2012, projected not as a hologram but by the Victorian stage illusion still called Pepper's ghost, and the voices of dead performers are now routinely synthesized. In December 2020, the month of *Cyberpunk 2077*'s release, Microsoft was granted a patent, filed in 2017, for conversational agents modeled on specific individuals, the dead not excluded. Its components read like a specification for Johnny Silverhand: a personality index built from a person's messages and posts, a "voice font" generated from their recordings, and a two- or three-dimensional model built from their photographs and videos. The patent adds that the specific person may be the user, who could thereby train a replacement for themselves. A Microsoft executive called the idea disturbing and said he knew of no plan to build it.

Each of these cases poses the questions this dissertation has extracted from Night City: who commands the ecphory, who profits from the return, and whether the dead retain any claim to rest. *Cyberpunk 2077* is thus less a vision of the future than a critical thanatology of the present, and its value as a philosophical text lies in the precision with which it anticipates a political economy its players already inhabit.

Limits and Further Research 12.4

Several limits require acknowledgment. The techno-Orientalist and racial coding of the setting deserves fuller treatment than a study centered on death could give it, particularly with respect to Arasaka, the Tyger Claws, and the Voodoo Boys, and the same holds for gender and the modular body, which section 7.8 opens rather than closes. The study has read the game as a text rather than as a practice, and reception research on players' memorial behavior, their attachments to Johnny, and their choices among endings would test its claims. Pondsmith's tabletop remains a living practice through *Cyberpunk RED*, and its play communities produce their own necrologies. A comparative procedural thanatology would extend the method to other works: *SOMA* (2015), whose coin toss stages the copy problem in the first person; *NieR: Automata* (2017), whose final ending asks players to delete their own save data to help strangers, a ludic act of requiescence; *Disco Elysium* (2019), whose protagonist's mind is a parliament of competing inner voices; *Death Stranding* (2019), whose dead return as a geological stratum; and *Hades* (2020), which makes the underworld a home. The sequel CD PROJEKT RED has announced under the codename Orion will test whether the posthumous turn persists in the franchise.

Coda: Learning to Die in the City That Enclosed Death 12.5

Cicero held that the whole life of philosophers is a preparation for death, and Montaigne, following him, wrote that to philosophize is to learn how to die. Derrida opened *Specters of Marx* with a sentence spoken by someone who would finally like to learn to live, and observed that this can be learned only from the other and by death, in the space between life and death, in the company of ghosts. *Cyberpunk 2077* teaches both lessons at once. Its protagonist learns to live by learning to die in the company of a ghost, and the player, who lingers in the open world while V's weeks refuse to tick, learns that the evasion of death and the love of life are not easily told apart.

In a world that has enclosed death, learning to die becomes a political act. It means refusing the Vault, the Reel, and the Shop, and choosing instead the Altar, the radio, the clan, and the ordinary life that *The Tower* restores. Classical cyberpunk asked whether the human survives the machine. *Cyberpunk 2077* asks whether death survives capital. Its answer, distributed across its endings, is conditional: death

survives only where the street keeps finding its own uses for the dead—where the dead are fed rather than farmed, remembered rather than reactivated, mourned rather than owned. Benjamin's warning stands at the threshold of the argument and at its end. Even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. Night City shows what that victory would look like. Its street shows that it has not yet been won.

Works Cited *(Selected)*

PRIMARY SOURCES

CD PROJEKT RED. *Cyberpunk 2077*. Video game. 2020.

CD PROJEKT RED. *Cyberpunk 2077: Phantom Liberty*. Video game expansion. 2023.

Pondsmith, Mike. *Cyberpunk: The Roleplaying Game of the Dark Future*. R. Talsorian Games, 1988.

Pondsmith, Mike. *Cyberpunk 2020*. R. Talsorian Games, 1990.

Pondsmith, Mike. *Cyberpunk V3.0*. R. Talsorian Games, 2005.

Pondsmith, Mike, et al. *Cyberpunk RED*. R. Talsorian Games, 2020.

Studio Trigger and CD PROJEKT RED. *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*. Directed by Hiroyuki Imaishi. Netflix, 2022.

Williams, Walter Jon, and R. Talsorian Games. *Hardwired: The Sourcebook*. 1989.

LITERARY, CINEMATIC, TELEVISUAL, LUDIC, AND MUSICAL WORKS

Bester, Alfred. *The Stars My Destination*. 1956.
Bigelow, Kathryn, dir. *Strange Days*. 1995.
Borges, Jorge Luis. "The Immortal." 1947.
Brooker, Charlie, creator. *Black Mirror*. 2011–. Episodes cited: "Be Right Back" (2013); "White Christmas" (2014).
Brunner, John. *The Shockwave Rider*. 1975.
Cadigan, Pat. *Synners*. 1991.
Čapek, Karel. *The Makropulos Affair*. 1922.
Coleman, Ornette. *The Shape of Jazz to Come*. Album. 1959.
Daniels, Greg, creator. *Upload*. 2020–.
Dante Alighieri. *Inferno*. c. 1308–21.
Debussy, Claude. "La cathédrale engloutie." *Préludes*, Book I. 1910.
Dick, Philip K. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* 1968.
Dick, Philip K. *Ubik*. 1969.
Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *Demons*. 1871–72.
Effinger, George Alec. *When Gravity Fails*. 1987.
Egan, Greg. "Learning to Be Me." 1990.
Eliot, T. S. *The Waste Land*. 1922.
Erickson, Dan, creator. *Severance*. 2022–.
Frictional Games. *SOMA*. Video game. 2015.
Gibson, William. "Johnny Mnemonic." 1981.
Gibson, William. "Burning Chrome." 1982.
Gibson, William. *Neuromancer*. 1984.
Gibson, William. *Count Zero*. 1986.
Gibson, William. *Mona Lisa Overdrive*. 1988.
Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. *Faust*. Parts I and II. 1808, 1832.
Halperin, Victor, dir. *White Zombie*. 1932.
Hoffmann, E. T. A. "Der Sandmann." 1816.
Kafka, Franz. "The Hunter Gracchus." Written 1917; published 1931.
Kafka, Franz. *The Trial*. 1925. *The Castle*. 1926.
Kojima Productions. *Death Stranding*. Video game. 2019.
Lem, Stanisław. *Solaris*. 1961.
Longo, Robert, dir. *Johnny Mnemonic*. 1995.
Marlowe, Christopher. *Doctor Faustus*. c. 1592.
Milton, John. *Paradise Lost*. 1667.
Monk, Thelonious, and Kenny Clarke. "Epistrophy." 1941.
Morgan, Richard K. *Altered Carbon*. 2002.
Nolan, Jonathan, and Lisa Joy, creators. *Westworld*. 2016–22.
Oshii, Mamoru, dir. *Ghost in the Shell*. 1995.
Otomo, Katsuhiro. *Akira*. Manga, 1982–90; film, 1988.
PlatinumGames. *NieR: Automata*. Video game. 2017.
Refused. *The Shape of Punk to Come*. Album. 1998.
Rucker, Rudy. *Software*. 1982.
Scott, Ridley, dir. *Blade Runner*. 1982.
Shakespeare, William. *The Merchant of Venice*. c. 1596–97.
Shakespeare, William. *Hamlet*. c. 1600.
Smith, Pamela Colman, and A. E. Waite. Rider–Waite–Smith tarot deck. 1909.
Stahelski, Chad, dir. *John Wick*. 2014.
Supergiant Games. *Hades*. Video game. 2020.
Swift, Jonathan. *Gulliver's Travels*. 1726.
Trumbull, Douglas, dir. *Brainstorm*. 1983.
Villeneuve, Denis, dir. *Blade Runner 2049*. 2017.
Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, Auguste. *L'Ève future*. 1886.
Wachowski, Lana, and Lilly Wachowski, dirs. *The Matrix*. 1999.
Williams, Walter Jon. *Hardwired*. 1986.
ZA/UM. *Disco Elysium*. Video game. 2019.

THEORETICAL, CRITICAL, HISTORICAL, AND LEGAL WORKS

Aarseth, Espen J. *Cybertext: Perspectives on Ergodic Literature*. 1997.

Abraham, Nicolas, and Maria Torok. *The Shell and the Kernel*. French edition 1978; including "Mourning or Melancholia: Introjection versus Incorporation" (1972) and "Notes on the Phantom" (1975).

Agamben, Giorgio. *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*. 1995.

Bakunin, Mikhail. "The Reaction in Germany." 1842.

Banerjee, Subhabrata Bobby. "Necrocapitalism." *Organization Studies* 29.12 (2008).

Barthes, Roland. *Camera Lucida*. 1980.

Bataille, Georges. *Inner Experience*. 1943.

Baudelaire, Charles. "The Painter of Modern Life." 1863.

Baudrillard, Jean. *Symbolic Exchange and Death*. 1976.

Baudrillard, Jean. *Simulacra and Simulation*. 1981.

Bazin, André. "The Ontology of the Photographic Image." 1945.

Becker, Ernest. *The Denial of Death*. 1973.

Becker, Gary S. *Human Capital*. 1964.

Belting, Hans. *An Anthropology of Images*. German edition 2001.

Benjamin, Walter. "Capitalism as Religion." 1921.

Benjamin, Walter. "Little History of Photography." 1931.

Benjamin, Walter. "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility." 1935–36.

Benjamin, Walter. "The Storyteller." 1936.

Benjamin, Walter. "On the Concept of History." 1940.

Berardi, Franco "Bifo." *After the Future*. 2011.

Blake, William. *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell*. c. 1790–93.

Blanchot, Maurice. *L'Arrêt de mort*. 1948.

Blanchot, Maurice. *L'Espace littéraire*. 1955.

Bogost, Ian. *Persuasive Games: The Expressive Power of Videogames*. 2007.

Bostrom, Nick. *Superintelligence: Paths, Dangers, Strategies*. 2014.

Bourdieu, Pierre. "The Forms of Capital." 1986.

Braidotti, Rosi. *The Posthuman*. 2013.

Brown, Peter. *The Cult of the Saints*. 1981.

Buffon, Georges-Louis Leclerc, comte de. *Discours sur le style*. 1753.

Bukatman, Scott. *Terminal Identity*. 1993.

Burgess, Ernest W. "The Growth of the City." 1925.

Burke, Edmund. *Reflections on the Revolution in France*. 1790.

Butler, Joseph. "Of Personal Identity." 1736.

Butler, Judith. *Gender Trouble*. 1990.

Camus, Albert. *The Myth of Sisyphus*. 1942.

Camus, Albert. *The Rebel*. 1951.

Chiffoleau, Jacques. *La Comptabilité de l'au-delà*. 1980.

Clark, Andy. *Natural-Born Cyborgs*. 2003.

Clark, Andy, and David Chalmers. "The Extended Mind." *Analysis* 58 (1998).

Clastres, Pierre. *Society Against the State*. 1974.

Court of Justice of the European Union. *Google Spain SL v. Agencia Española de Protección de Datos*, Case C-131/12. 2014.

Csicsery-Ronay, Istvan, Jr. "Cyberpunk and Neuromanticism." *Mississippi Review* 16.2–3 (1988).

Davis, Mike. *Beyond Blade Runner: Urban Control, the Ecology of Fear*. 1992.

Davis, Mike. *Ecology of Fear*. 1998.

Dean, Jodi. "Neofeudalism: The End of Capitalism?" 2020.

Debord, Guy. *The Society of the Spectacle*. 1967.

Debray, Régis. *Vie et mort de l'image*. 1992.

Deleuze, Gilles, and Félix Guattari. *A Thousand Plateaus*. 1980.

Deren, Maya. *Divine Horsemen: The Living Gods of Haiti*. 1953.

Derrida, Jacques. "Plato's Pharmacy." 1968.

Derrida, Jacques. "Fors." 1976.

Derrida, Jacques. "Living On: Border Lines." 1979.

Derrida, Jacques. *Specters of Marx*. 1993.

Derrida, Jacques. *Archive Fever*. 1995.

Descartes, René. *Meditations on First Philosophy*. 1641.

Dyer-Witheford, Nick, and Greig de Peuter. *Games of Empire*. 2009.

European Union. Regulation (EU) 2016/679 (General Data Protection Regulation). 2016.

Fagone, Jason. "The Jessica Simulation." *San Francisco Chronicle*. 2021.

Fisher, Mark. *Ghosts of My Life*. 2014.

Foster, Thomas. *The Souls of Cyberfolk*. 2005.

Foucault, Michel. "A Preface to Transgression." 1963.

Foucault, Michel. "Nietzsche, Genealogy, History." 1971.

Foucault, Michel. *The History of Sexuality*, vol. 1. 1976.

Foucault, Michel. *"Society Must Be Defended."* Lectures, 1975–76.

Foucault, Michel. *The Birth of Biopolitics*. Lectures, 1978–79.

Foucault, Michel. "What Is Enlightenment?" 1984.

France. *Loi pour une République numérique*. 2016.

Frank, Thomas. *The Conquest of Cool*. 1997.

Frazer, James George. *The Golden Bough*. 1890.

Freud, Sigmund. *Totem and Taboo*. 1913.

Freud, Sigmund. "Mourning and Melancholia." 1917.

Freud, Sigmund. "The Uncanny." 1919.

Freud, Sigmund. *Civilization and Its Discontents*. 1930.

Geary, Patrick J. *Furta Sacra: Thefts of Relics in the Central Middle Ages*. 1978.

Gehlen, Arnold. *Der Mensch*. 1940.

Goffman, Erving. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. 1959.

Gombrich, E. H. *Aby Warburg: An Intellectual Biography*. 1970.

Graeber, David. *Debt: The First 5,000 Years*. 2011.

Hahn, Cynthia. "The Voices of the Saints: Speaking Reliquaries." *Gesta* 36.1 (1997).

Halliday, M. A. K. "Anti-Languages." *American Anthropologist* 78.3 (1976).
Han, Byung-Chul. *The Burnout Society*. 2010.
Haraway, Donna. "A Cyborg Manifesto." 1985.
Hardt, Michael, and Antonio Negri. *Empire*. 2000.
Harvey, David. *The New Imperialism*. 2003.
Hayles, N. Katherine. *How We Became Posthuman*. 1999.
Heath, Joseph, and Andrew Potter. *The Rebel Sell*. 2004.
Hebdige, Dick. *Subculture: The Meaning of Style*. 1979.
Hegel, G. W. F. *Phenomenology of Spirit*. 1807.
Heidegger, Martin. *Being and Time*. 1927.
Heidegger, Martin. "The Question Concerning Technology." 1954.
Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan*. 1651.
Hobbes, Thomas. *De Corpore*. 1655.
Hochschild, Arlie Russell. *The Managed Heart*. 1983.
Hocking, Clint. "Ludonarrative Dissonance in Bioshock." 2007.
Hoffman, David E. *The Dead Hand*. 2009.
Hollanek, Tomasz, and Katarzyna Nowaczyk-Basińska. "Griefbots, Deadbots, Postmortem Avatars." *Philosophy & Technology* 37 (2024).
Hollinger, Veronica. "Cybernetic Deconstructions: Cyberpunk and Postmodernism." *Mosaic* 23.2 (1990).
Hume, David. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. 1739–40.
Husserl, Edmund. *On the Phenomenology of the Consciousness of Internal Time*. Lectures from 1905; published 1928.
Hutcheon, Linda. *The Politics of Postmodernism*. 1989.
Jackson, Frank. "Epiphenomenal Qualia." 1982.
Jameson, Fredric. *Postmodernism, or, The Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*. 1991.
Jaynes, Julian. *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind*. 1976.
Jefferson, Thomas. Letter to James Madison, 6 September 1789.
Josselyn, Sheena A., and Susumu Tonegawa. "Memory Engrams: Recalling the Past and Imagining the Future." *Science* 367 (2020).
Jung, C. G. *Aion*. 1951.
Juul, Jesper. *The Art of Failure*. 2013.
Kant, Immanuel. *The Metaphysics of Morals*. 1797.
Kittler, Friedrich. *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter*. 1986.
Lacan, Jacques. "The Function and Field of Speech and Language in Psychoanalysis." 1953.
Lashley, Karl. "In Search of the Engram." 1950.
Le Goff, Jacques. *The Birth of Purgatory*. 1981.
Leroi-Gourhan, André. *Gesture and Speech*. 1964–65.
Lichtenberg, Georg Christoph. *Sudelbücher* (Waste Books). 1765–99.
Lifton, Robert Jay. *The Broken Connection*. 1979.
Linebaugh, Peter. "The Tyburn Riot Against the Surgeons." 1975.
Liu, Xu, et al. "Optogenetic Stimulation of a Hippocampal Engram Activates Fear Memory Recall." *Nature* 484 (2012).
Locke, John. *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. 2nd ed. 1694.
Luther, Martin. *Ninety-Five Theses*. 1517.
Lyng, Stephen. "Edgework: A Social Psychological Analysis of Voluntary Risk Taking." *American Journal of Sociology* 95.4 (1990).
Marcus, Greil. *Lipstick Traces*. 1989.
Marx, Karl. *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*.
Marx, Karl. *The Eighteenth Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte*. 1852.
Marx, Karl. *Capital*, vol. 1. 1867.
Mauss, Marcel. *The Gift*. 1925.
Mbembe, Achille. "Necropolitics." *Public Culture* 15.1 (2003).
McCaffery, Larry, ed. *Storming the Reality Studio*. 1991.
McFarlane, Anna, Graham J. Murphy, and Lars Schmeink, eds. *The Routledge Companion to Cyberpunk Culture*. 2020.
McLuhan, Marshall. *Understanding Media*. 1964.
Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. *Phenomenology of Perception*. 1945.
Metzinger, Thomas. *Being No One*. 2003.
Metzinger, Thomas. *The Ego Tunnel*. 2009.
Microsoft Technology Licensing. US Patent 10,853,717, "Creating a Conversational Chat Bot of a Specific Person." 2020.
Montaigne, Michel de. *Essais*. 1580–95.
Morley, David, and Kevin Robins. *Spaces of Identity*. 1995.
Murphy, Graham J., and Lars Schmeink, eds. *Cyberpunk and Visual Culture*. 2018.
Nagel, Thomas. "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" 1974.
Nagy, Gregory. *The Best of the Achaeans*. 1979.
Nakamura, Lisa. *Cybertypes*. 2002.
Nechayev, Sergei. *Catechism of a Revolutionary*. 1869.
Nichols, Sallie. *Jung and Tarot: An Archetypal Journey*. 1980.
Nietzsche, Friedrich. *On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life*. 1874.
Nietzsche, Friedrich. *The Gay Science*. 1882.
Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*. 1883–85.
Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Beyond Good and Evil*. 1886.
Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Ecce Homo*. Written 1888; published 1908.
Nozick, Robert. *Anarchy, State, and Utopia*. 1974.
Nozick, Robert. *Philosophical Explanations*. 1981.
Öhman, Carl, and Luciano Floridi. "The Political Economy of Death in the Age of Information." *Minds and Machines* 27 (2017).
Öhman, Carl, and Luciano Floridi. "An Ethical Framework for the Digital Afterlife Industry." *Nature Human Behaviour* 2 (2018).
Öhman, Carl J., and David Watson. "Are the Dead Taking Over Facebook?" *Big Data & Society* 6.1 (2019).
Paine, Thomas. *Rights of Man*. 1791.
Parfit, Derek. *Reasons and Persons*. 1984.
Patterson, Orlando. *Slavery and Social Death*. 1982.
Paz, Octavio. *The Labyrinth of Solitude*. 1950.
Peters, John Durham. *Speaking into the Air*. 1999.

Pietz, William. "The Problem of the Fetish." *RES* 9, 13, 16 (1985–88).
Preciado, Paul B. *Testo Junkie*. 2008.
Ramirez, Steve, et al. "Creating a False Memory in the Hippocampus." *Science* 341 (2013).
Rank, Otto. *Der Doppelgänger*. 1914.
Reid, Thomas. *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*. 1785.
Richardson, Ruth. *Death, Dissection and the Destitute*. 1987.
Roh, David S., Betsy Huang, and Greta A. Niu, eds. *Techno-Orientalism*. 2015.
Sartre, Jean-Paul. *Being and Nothingness*. 1943.
Schmitt, Carl. *Political Theology*. 1922.
Schmitt, Carl. *The Nomos of the Earth*. 1950.
Sconce, Jeffrey. *Haunted Media*. 2000.
Semon, Richard. *Die Mneme*. 1904.
Shelley, Percy Bysshe. *A Defence of Poetry*. Written 1821; published 1840.
Slobodian, Quinn. *Crack-Up Capitalism*. 2023.
Smith, Adam. *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*. 1759.
Smith, Adam. *The Wealth of Nations*. 1776.
Smithson, Robert. "A Tour of the Monuments of Passaic, New Jersey." 1967.
Sontag, Susan. *On Photography*. 1977.
Sontag, Susan. *Regarding the Pain of Others*. 2003.
Srnicek, Nick. *Platform Capitalism*. 2016.
Standing, Guy. *The Precariat*. 2011.
Sterling, Bruce, ed. *Mirrorshades: The Cyberpunk Anthology*. 1986.
Stiegler, Bernard. *Technics and Time*. 3 vols. 1994–2001.
Thompson, Hunter S. *Hell's Angels*. 1966.
Vaneigem, Raoul. *The Revolution of Everyday Life*. 1967.
Varoufakis, Yanis. *Technofeudalism*. 2023.
Warburg, Aby. *Mnemosyne Atlas*. 1924–29.
Wilde, Oscar. "Phrases and Philosophies for the Use of the Young." 1894.
Williams, Bernard. "The Self and the Future." 1970.
Williams, Bernard. "The Makropulos Case: Reflections on the Tedium of Immortality." 1973.
Yamamoto Tsunetomo. *Hagakure*. Dictated c. 1709–16.
Yudkowsky, Eliezer. "The AI-Box Experiment." 2002.

CLASSICAL AND PREMODERN TEXTS

The Epic of Gilgamesh. Standard Babylonian version and Old Babylonian fragments.
Homer. *Iliad*; *Odyssey*.
Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite.
Hesiod. *Theogony*.
Plato. *Apology*; *Cratylus*; *Gorgias*; *Phaedrus*; *Protagoras*; *Republic*; *Theaetetus*.
Aristotle. *De Anima*.
Lucretius. *De rerum natura*.
Cicero. *Tusculan Disputations*.
Virgil. *Georgics*; *Aeneid*.
Ovid. *Metamorphoses*.
Petronius. *Satyricon*.
Polybius. *Histories*.
Plutarch. *Life of Theseus*.
Aulus Gellius. *Noctes Atticae*.
Philostratus. *Life of Apollonius of Tyana*.
Aelius Donatus. *Life of Virgil*.
Second Letter to the Thessalonians.
Augustine. *The City of God*.
Proclus. *Elements of Theology*.
Kojiki. 712.
Thomas Aquinas. *Commentary on the First Letter to the Corinthians*.

ADDITIONAL WORKS CITED IN REVISION

Agamben, Giorgio. *Remnants of Auschwitz: The Witness and the Archive*. 1998.
Bataille, Georges. *The Accursed Share*. 1949.
Baucom, Ian. *Specters of the Atlantic: Finance Capital, Slavery, and the Philosophy of History*. 2005.
Braun, Joseph. *Die Reliquiare des christlichen Kultes und ihre Entwicklung*. 1940.
CNIL, Laboratoire d'innovation numérique. *Our Data After Us* (Cahier IP no. 10). 2025.
Court of King's Bench. *Gregson v. Gilbert*. 1783.
Csicsery-Ronay, Istvan, Jr. "Antimancer: Cybernetics and Art in Gibson's *Count Zero*." *Science Fiction Studies* 22.1 (1995).
Deleuze, Gilles. "Postscript on the Societies of Control." 1990.
Dery, Mark. "Black to the Future." 1994.
Eshun, Kodwo. "Further Considerations on Afrofuturism." *CR: The New Centennial Review* 3.2 (2003).
Hartman, Saidiya. "Venus in Two Acts." *Small Axe* 26 (2008).
Jefferson, Thomas. Letter to John Cartwright, 5 June 1824.
Levi, Primo. *The Drowned and the Saved*. 1986.
Mishima, Yukio. *Hagakure nyūmon*. 1967.
Sontag, Susan. "Notes on 'Camp'." 1964.
Young, Neil, and Crazy Horse. "Hey Hey, My My (Into the Black)." *Rust Never Sleeps*. 1979.
Young, Neil, and Crazy Horse. *Sleeps with Angels*. Album. 1994.

Verification Notes (30 October 2026)

Claims about the endings, Evelyn Parker's fate, the Arasaka succession, Pondsmith's rules of the cyberpunk, and *Phantom Liberty* were checked against the sources below, and the text was corrected where they differed from the first draft. The GamesRadar+ guide was read in full; the others were consulted through search results.

GamesRadar+, "All Cyberpunk 2077 endings and how to get them" · gamesradar.com — every ending, including *The Tower* and the ending reached by suicide.

Sportskeeda, "Can you save Evelyn Parker in Cyberpunk 2077?" · sportskeeda.com; Twinfinite, "Can You Save Evelyn?" · twinfinite.net; SegmentNext, "Disasterpiece" · segmentnext.com; Vulkk, "The Space In Between" · vulkk.com — Evelyn Parker and the chain of brokers.

Villains Wiki, "Yorinobu Arasaka" · villains.fandom.com; Cyberpunk Wiki · cyberpunk.fandom.com; TheGamer · thegamer.com — the Arasaka succession and the NetWatch arrangement.

R. Talsorian Games · rtalsoriangames.com; PC Gamer, "The origins of Cyberpunk 2077" · pcgamer.com; Meeple Mountain, *Cyberpunk 2020* review · meeplemountain.com; Roll20, *Cyberpunk RED* basic rules · roll20.net — the rules of the cyberpunk and *2020*'s statistics.

GameSpot, *Phantom Liberty* endings guide · gamespot.com; Vulkk, "Somewhat Damaged" · vulkk.com — Cynosure, Cerberus, and the two branches.

Second pass: R. Talsorian Games, Night City timeline · rtalsoriangames.com; PC Gamer, Cyberpunk RPG timeline · pcgamer.com; Cyberpunk Wiki, "A.I." · cyberpunk.fandom.com; PC Invasion · pcinvasion.com — Night City's founding, Bartmoss, the DataKrash, and the Blackwall. Cyberpunk Wiki, "Afterlife" · cyberpunk.fandom.com; Looper · looper.com; Cyberpunk Wiki, "Claire Russell" · cyberpunk.fandom.com; What to Watch · whattowatch.com — the Afterlife and its menu. Destructoid · destructoid.com; Dot Esports · dotesports.com; Cyberpunk Wiki, "Intelligence" · cyberpunk.fandom.com — the Voodoo Boys. ScienceDaily (University of Cambridge) · sciencedaily.com; Down To Earth · downtoearth.org.in; The Boston Globe · bostonglobe.com; Live Science · livescience.com — the digital afterlife industry.

Third pass: Twinfinite · twinfinite.net; Fandom, "How Cyberpunk: Edgerunners Expands on CDPR's Night City Lore" · fandom.com; Kosgames · kosgames.com; The Cosmic Circus · thecosmiccircus.com; Cyberpunk Wiki, "Maine" · cyberpunk.fandom.com — Gloria Martinez and the Sandevistan. PC Gamer, "Who is Mr. Blue Eyes?" · pcgamer.com; NME · nme.com; Kotaku Australia · kotaku.com.au — "Dream On." Cyberpunk Wiki, "Cyberpunk 2077 Romance" · cyberpunk.fandom.com; PCGamesN · pcgamesn.com — romance requirements. Snopes · snopes.com; Laptop Mag · laptopmag.com — the Microsoft patent. GDPR, Recital 27 · gdpr-text.com; CNIL LINC, "Our Data After Us" · linc.cnil.fr; donneespersonnelles.fr · donneespersonnelles.fr — the law of post-mortem data. Medievalists.net, on Hahn (1997) · medievalists.net; Lahti, "Talkative Head Reliquaries" · journals.lub.lu.se; Victoria and Albert Museum · collections.vam.ac.uk — speaking reliquaries.

Fourth pass: BBVA OpenMind · bbvaopenmind.com; i-D · i-d.co — the Mazurenko chatbot. Miami New Times · miaminewtimes.com; Tri-State Defender · tri-statedefender.com — the Coachella performance. LSE Research Online · researchonline.lse.ac.uk; case summary · inimoigustegiid.ee — *Google Spain*. University of Pennsylvania Libraries · find.library.upenn.edu; Chiffoleau, EHESS · ehess.academia.edu — Chiffoleau. The Chronicle of Higher Education · chronicle.com; University of Leeds · performing-mountains.leeds.ac.uk — Lyng. *Science Fiction Studies*, Nixon (1992) · depauw.edu; *Science Fiction Studies*, Fekete · depauw.edu; *Science Fiction Studies*, Csicsery-Ronay (1995) · depauw.edu — Csicsery-Ronay.

Fifth pass: Econlib, *Capital*, author's prefaces · econlib.org; CUNY Manifold edition of *Capital* · cuny.manifoldapp.org; *Cultural Logic*, on Marx's vampires · ojs.library.ubc.ca — Marx. Benjamin, "Über den Begriff der Geschichte," after *Gesammelte Schriften* I/2 · unifr.ch; a second German text · lernhelfer.de — Benjamin. LitCharts, *Leviathan*, chapter 29 · litcharts.com; Laudani, *Storicamente* · storicamente.org — Hobbes. Bundestag committee document quoting Kant · bundestag.de — Kant.

Sixth pass: Founders Online, Jefferson to Madison, 6 September 1789 · founders.archives.gov; *Journal of the American Revolution*, on Madison's reply · allthingsliberty.com; Jefferson to Cartwright, 1824, as quoted at concon.info · concon.info — Jefferson and Madison. Paine, *Rights of Man*, excerpt · connexions.org; Standard Ebooks, *Rights of Man* · standardebooks.org; Illinois State Board of Education, Burke and Paine passages · isbe.net — Paine and Burke. Project Gutenberg, Wilde, *Shorter Prose Pieces* · gutenberg.org; *Purple*, Sontag's "Notes on Camp" · purple.fr — Wilde. Bible Study Tools, *Ninety-Five Theses* · biblestudytools.com; Ligonier Ministries · learn.ligonier.org; Ages Digital Library · media.sabda.org — Luther. William Gibson Wiki, citing *Neuromancer*, pp. 243–44 · williamgibson.fandom.com; areq.net, citing Porush and Olsen · areq.net — Gibson.

A second through fifth pass on the same date checked the founding of Night City, Rache Bartmoss and the DataKrash, the Blackwall, the Afterlife and Claire Russell's role at its bar, the Voodoo Boys questline, Gloria Martinez's death and the provenance of David Martinez's Sandevistan, "Dream On," the romance requirements, the Microsoft patent, the Mazurenko chatbot, the 2012 Coachella performance, GDPR Recital 27, France's 2016 law, the *Google Spain* judgment, Cynthia Hahn's article, Jacques Chiffoleau's study, Stephen Lyng on edgework, Istvan Csicsery-Ronay on neuromanticism, and the digital-afterlife scholarship of Hollanek and Nowaczyk-Basińska and of Öhman and Watson. The text was corrected and strengthened accordingly; an unconfirmed detail of Claire Russell's backstory and an unconfirmed claim about how the game assigns V's pronouns were removed.

The fifth and sixth passes checked direct quotations against original or standard texts: the preface to *Capital* (its English text and the French maxim) and its vampire passage; Benjamin's sixth thesis in German; Hobbes's *Leviathan*, chapter 29; Kant's phrase *partialer Selbstmord*, confirmed in a German edition of his lectures on ethics, which corresponds to the cited passage of the *Metaphysics of Morals* (6:423); Jefferson's letter to Madison and Madison's reply; Paine's *Rights of Man* and Burke's *Reflections*; Wilde's "Phrases and Philosophies"; Luther's *Ninety-Five Theses*; and the passage of *Neuromancer* quoted in Chapter One. The sixth pass also corrected a chronological slip: Burke did not answer Jefferson, whose letter was private; the public exchange was between Burke and Paine. The German of the Marx epigraph is given from the standard German text and was not re-located. English quotations from *Capital* follow the Moore–Aveling translation (1887); the Benjamin epigraph and the renderings of Benjamin's other theses are the author's; other quotations from works first published in other languages follow standard English translations (Strachey for Freud, Bower for Camus, Nicholson-Smith for Vaneigem, Joughin for Deleuze) or are the author's renderings. Gibson's "Burning Chrome" aphorism, the classical sources, and the wider body of canonical philosophical texts were not re-checked page by page; Porush and Olsen are cited after a secondary summary.

A final read-through for flow and consistency made four further corrections: it removed an unverified claim that Night City's incumbent mayor had been murdered; corrected an overstatement that Claire Russell is the only member of the cast without cyberware; confined the lethal data payload of "Johnny

Mnemonic" to Robert Longo's film, where it originates; and replaced the claim that the city's own powers killed Richard Night, whose killer was never found. It also standardized American spelling and Pondsmith's own term, "rules," for the four maxims of the cyberpunk, sorted the works added in revision alphabetically, and added entries for Bakunin and Banerjee, who were cited in the text but missing from the Works Cited.

KEYWORDS

Cyberpunk 2077 | *Cyberpunk 2020* | Mike Pondsmith | CD PROJEKT RED | *Phantom Liberty* | *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* | cyberpunk studies | game studies | posthumanism | the posthumous condition | necromanticism | necromantic capital | necromantic power | accumulation by exhumation | the enclosure of death | the Relic-form | commodity fetishism | relic cult | purgatory | engram | ecphory | ecphoric sovereignty | engrammatic personhood | personal identity | mind uploading | Derek Parfit | hauntology | bispectrality | mourning and melancholia | the crypt | inheritance | requiescence | biopolitics | necropolitics | *katechon* | artificial intelligence containment | techno-Orientalism | braindance | pharmacopornography | media necrology | cyberpsychosis | human capital | the achievement society | procedural rhetoric | procedural thanatology | ludonarrative dissonance | being-toward-death | the Myth of Er | *kleos* and *nostos* | Orpheus | *Gilgamesh* | Faust | tarot | Johnny Silverhand | the digital afterlife industry | griefbots | the right to be forgotten | chattel slavery | testimony | gender and the modular body

Even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins.